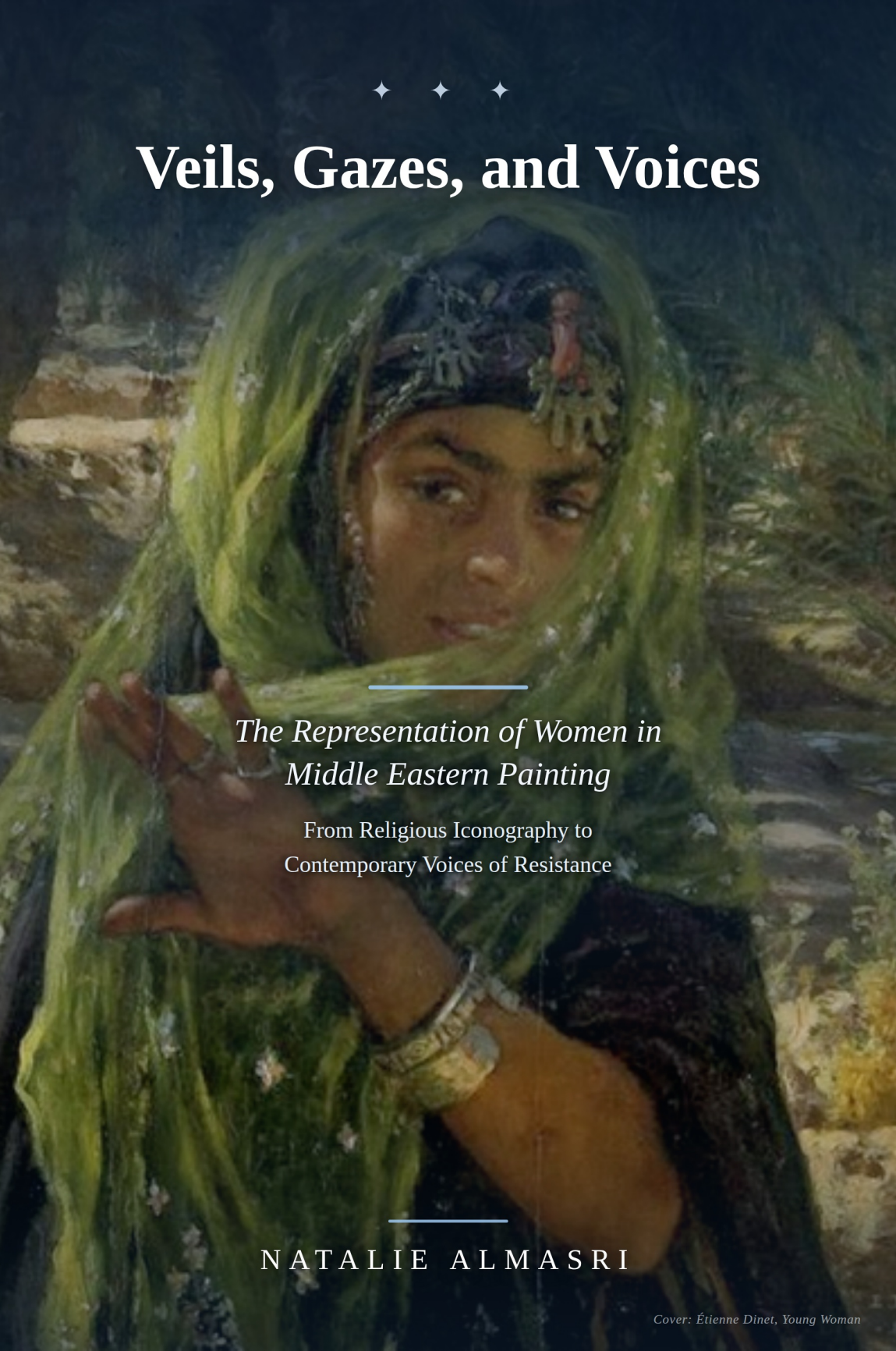




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Veils, Gazes, and Voices

*The Representation of Women in
Middle Eastern Painting*

From Religious Iconography to
Contemporary Voices of Resistance

NATALIE ALMASRI

Cover: Étienne Dinet, *Young Woman*

Veils, Gazes, and Voices

The Representation of Women in Middle Eastern Painting

First edition

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This book is an expanded scholarly edition of the master's thesis originally submitted to Università IUAV di Venezia, Corso di Laurea Magistrale in Arti Visive e Moda, under the supervision of Professoressa Angela Vettese and Professor Paolo Garbolino, in the academic year 2022/2023.

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*For the women whose faces filled the canvases
long before their voices filled the rooms.*

And for my mother — my first patron of the arts.



“Through their art, Middle Eastern women artists challenge stereotypes and reclaim their narratives, offering a fresh perspective on the diverse experiences of women in the region.”

— Lalla Essaydi

“The Orient was almost a European invention, and had been since antiquity a place of romance, exotic beings, haunting memories and landscapes, remarkable experiences.”

— Edward Said, *Orientalism* (1978)

“It’s not the physical but the ideological veils of misunderstanding that are at issue.”

— Fatema Mernissi

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Foreword

When a young Palestinian scholar first set out to map the representation of women in Middle Eastern painting, she was answering a question that has haunted art history for at least two centuries: who, exactly, is allowed to look — and who is condemned to be looked at? The discipline has long borrowed its categories from the very Europe that, between 1798 and 1956, dispatched its painters to North Africa and the Levant in the wake of its armies. The “Orient” it produced on canvas — voluptuous, silent, and reliably feminine — was not the Middle East. It was a screen on which a particular kind of European desire could be projected.

The pages that follow are a corrective. They are not a denunciation of Orientalist painting, which would be too easy, nor an uncritical celebration of its contemporary heirs, which would be too cheap. Rather, they constitute a careful, multilingual reading of nearly five centuries of images, drawn from collections in Cairo, Istanbul, Tehran, Riga, Beirut, Ramallah, Paris, and New York. The author moves with equal facility between the studio of Carle van Loo and the Instagram feed of an exiled Iranian queer painter; between the seventeenth-century miniature in a Safavid manuscript and the Acrylic-and-glitter portraits of a Jordanian-American artist working out of Brooklyn.

What emerges is not a single thesis but a method — an attentiveness to the subtle cultural negotiation that occurs every time a Middle Eastern woman enters the visual field, whether as subject, painter, patron, or viewer. It is a book that respects the difficult truth that representation in this region is never innocent. The veil is at once garment, theology, political identifier, and Western fetish. The harem is at once architectural fact, family arrangement, and pornographic fantasy.

The female nude is at once classical heritage and contemporary scandal. To read these images well requires that we hold all of these in view at once.

Natalie Almasri does so with rigour, and — more rare in academic writing — with affection. She loves the painters she discusses, even when she disagrees with them. She is patient with sources from radically different ideological traditions, refusing to flatten Orientalism, Islamic aniconism, feminist art history, and queer theory into a single explanatory grid. The result is a book that will reward students of art history, gender studies, and Middle Eastern studies in equal measure, and one that should also find its way into the hands of museum-goers, gallery-goers, and ordinary readers who want to think about images more carefully than the news cycle invites them to.

Books on women and the Middle East have a tendency to fall into one of two traps. They are either pious about culture and silent about gender, or pious about gender and silent about culture. This book refuses both. It is at once a defence of the cultural specificity of Middle Eastern visual traditions and an unsentimental account of the violence those traditions have sometimes done to women's representation. It will start arguments. It will deserve to.

Venice — Ramallah - Nablus, 2026

Preface to the Book Edition

This book began life as a master's thesis, defended at the Università IUAV di Venezia in the summer of 2023. In the months that followed, I was struck by how often readers — students, colleagues, family members, and even people who had never set foot in an art gallery — asked me whether the work might exist in a longer form. The questions they raised in conversation were rarely about the artists I had discussed. They were, more often, about the artists I had not. Where, they wanted to know, was Shirin Neshat? Where was Mona Hatoum, Etel Adnan, Huguette Caland? Where were the women who had been cropped out of the standard art-historical canon, only to reappear, decades later, in retrospectives at the Tate, the Centre Pompidou, the Sharjah Biennial?

The book you hold in your hands is my attempt to answer those questions without losing the original spine of the thesis. I have kept the architecture of the original work — its five-chapter movement from religious iconography, through courtly portraiture and everyday life, to contemporary practice and the politics of gender and sexuality. But I have expanded each chapter substantially. Where the thesis asked questions, the book answers more of them. Where the thesis cited a single statistic, the book provides a context. Where the thesis introduced an artist in two paragraphs, the book — when the artist deserved it — gives her two pages.

I have also added a chapter-by-chapter set of running notes that integrate scholarship published since the thesis was filed: the rich body of work on the Ottoman harem produced by historians of the Topkapı archives, the surge of scholarship on Iranian women's photography after the "Woman, Life, Freedom" movement of 2022–23, and the ongoing public conversation about the role of regional museums (the Museum of Islamic

Art in Doha, the Sharjah Art Foundation, the Mathaf Arab Museum of Modern Art) as both custodians and contestants of the Western canon.

Some choices about scope have remained the same. The “Middle East” in this book is the region commonly designated by that English term — broadly, the Arab states, Turkey, Iran, and Palestine. I am aware that this geography is itself a colonial-cartographic invention, and where useful I have explained why a particular painting is best read with a different unit of analysis (Ottoman, Persianate, Mediterranean, diasporic). North Africa, in particular, demands an entire book of its own, and I have included only those Maghrebi works that bear directly on the broader argument.

The book retains the personal voice of the thesis. Some of the artists discussed here are people I have written to, met, or interviewed. Some of the ideas have been worked out in conversation with my supervisors and friends in Venice, in Ramallah where my family is rooted, and in Cairo, where I returned in the summer of 2025 to revisit the Mahmoud Said Museum. I have tried to carry the texture of those encounters into the prose without letting it overrun the analysis.

Finally, a note on translation. Where I quote from Arabic, Turkish, Persian, or Hebrew sources, the translations are mine unless otherwise indicated. I have tended to keep transliterations simple and reader-friendly rather than strict, and have used the most common English forms of names (Mahmoud Said rather than Maḥmūd Saʿīd, Osman Hamdi Bey rather than ‘Oṣmān Ḥamdī Bey). Specialists will, I hope, forgive me. Specialists, in my experience, almost always do.

Natalie Almasri

Spring 2026

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Completing this work has been a journey of growth, discovery, and perseverance. As I reflect on the long road from a master's thesis to a book, I am humbled and deeply grateful to the many individuals and institutions that have supported and guided me along the way.

First and foremost, I would like to express my profound appreciation to my thesis advisor, Professoressa Angela Vettese, and to Professor Paolo Garbolino. Their unwavering commitment to my academic and personal development has been the cornerstone of this endeavour. Their guidance, patience, and expertise have challenged me to strive for excellence. Without their willingness to entertain a sprawling topic and to read draft after draft of unwieldy chapters, the original thesis on which this book is based would not have been written.

I extend my heartfelt thanks to my family for their unending encouragement and belief in my abilities. Your love and support have been my driving force, propelling me through the challenges of this academic pursuit. To my parents, who carried with them from Palestine the understanding that art is not a luxury but a necessity, I owe more than these pages can repay.

To my friends and peers — in Venice, in Ramallah, in Cairo, in Beirut — your camaraderie and shared experiences have provided a vital source of motivation and inspiration. I am grateful for the countless conversations, debates, and late-night study sessions that have enriched my understanding of the subject matter.

I am indebted to the artists and curators who agreed to speak with me during the research for both the thesis and this book — among them, Nabil Anani, who welcomed me into his Ramallah studio in August 2023, and the staff of the Mahmoud Said Museum in Alexandria, the Pera Museum in Istanbul, the Sursock Museum in Beirut, and the Mathaf Arab Museum of Modern Art in Doha. Their willingness to share insights and access has been pivotal in the development of this research.

My gratitude extends to the academic community at Università IUAV di Venezia, which has provided an intellectually stimulating environment in which to learn and grow. The resources, facilities, and opportunities made available by the university — including its library and its lively visiting-artist programme — have been indispensable.

Lastly, I acknowledge the scholars and researchers whose pioneering work has paved the way for my own — Linda Nochlin, Edward Said, Wijdan Ali, Sarah Graham-Brown, Mary Ann Stevens, Nada Shabout, Salwa Mikdadi, Joseph Massad, and many others whose names appear in the bibliography. Their dedication to advancing knowledge in this field has been a guiding light throughout my research, and the disagreements I have with several of them in these pages are offered in the same spirit of scholarly companionship.

N. A.

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CHAPTER ONE

Foundations



Art, Identity, and the Woman in the Frame

1.1 Why this study, why now

A topic that spans centuries and encompasses an extensive variety of nations, faiths, and creative traditions, the depiction of women in Middle Eastern painting cannot be confined to a single chapter, a single century, or a single tradition. From ancient civilisations to contemporary art, women have been a central subject in the region's painting — and their portrayal has reflected, and at times resisted, the societal, cultural, and aesthetic conventions of their specific eras. Women in Middle Eastern painting have frequently been portrayed throughout history in a number of roles and settings: as embodiments of femininity and motherhood, representing splendour, grace, and fertility; as figures of religious devotion, modesty, and martyrdom; as cyphers in courtly intrigue; and, increasingly, as authors of their own image.

One of the principal aims of this book is to argue that the “woman in Middle Eastern painting” is not a single figure but a parliament of figures, often in argument with one another. Scheherazade's vivid storytelling in *One Thousand and One Nights* — a book widely known in Europe between the eighteenth century and the 1920s as the *Arabian Nights* — produced an indelible impression of the Eastern world as strange, beautiful, and

chaotic.¹ That impression travelled, in the saddlebags and sketchbooks of European artists, into hundreds of paintings that did not so much describe the Middle East as inscribe it with European desire. The challenge of writing this book has been to look at those paintings without becoming captive to them — and to look, with equal seriousness, at the Middle Eastern painters who painted alongside them, often in conversation, occasionally in opposition, and sometimes in altogether different idioms.

Like other artists living in Constantinople in the early eighteenth century, Jean-Baptiste Vanmour (born in Valenciennes in 1671) was commissioned by Europeans to paint them in Turkish costume. When these diplomats and travellers returned home, many of them brought oriental costumes — and, with them, a new market for paintings depicting people they imagined to be Eastern.² Tunisian artists such as François Boucher and Jean-Baptiste Le Prince became famous for their oriental scenes. Nicolas Lancret, Étienne Jeaurat, and Jacques de Lajoue gradually felt the impact of this Ottoman fashion, even when they had never set foot east of Marseille. By 1737, Carle van Loo was painting *The Grand Turk Giving a Concert to His Mistress* (Fig. 1) — an exotic confection that prefigures the theatrical orient of the next two centuries.

¹A sampling of these works includes: Gaston Diehl, *Delacroix au Maroc* (Rabat: Mission universitaire et culturelle française au Maroc, 1963); Maurice Arama, *Le Maroc de Delacroix* (Paris: Editions du Jaguar, 1987); Guy Dumur, *Delacroix et le Maroc* (Paris: Herscher, 1988); Maurice Sérullaz, *Delacroix in Morocco* (Paris: Institut du monde arabe / Flammarion, 1994); Author not indicated, *La Tanger des peintres: de Delacroix à Matisse* (Tangier: Tingis, 2003); Tahar Ben Jelloun, *Delacroix al Morocco* (Milan: F. M. Ricci, 2004); for Matisse, see Camille Cabana, *Le Maroc de Matisse* (Paris: Institut du monde arabe / Gallimard, 1999) and Jack Cowart et al., *Matisse in Morocco: The Paintings and Drawings, 1912–1913* (Washington, DC: National Gallery of Art, 1990).

²See Rasheed El-Enany, *Arab Representations of the Occident: East–West Encounters in Arabic Fiction* (London and New York: Routledge, 2006).



Fig. 1 — Carle van Loo, The Grand Turk Giving a Concert to His Mistress, oil on canvas, 1737. The painting's figures wear ostensibly Eastern costume, but the architecture is unmistakably French neoclassical: an early signal that the "Orient" of European painting was as much a wardrobe as a place.

The painting that Jacques Aved produced of Ambassador Said Mehmed Pasha — now in the National Art Museum at Versailles — sparked great interest in the Parisian art world of the 1740s, and it inspired aristocratic clients to commission their own “Turkish” portraits. The list of those who sat in front of Aved (and after him, of Antoine de Favray) included the Marquise de Sainte-Maure, the Marquise de Beaumont, and the Comtesse de Magnac. Their costumes were, at least in part, authentic Ottoman

garments transported back to France in trunks. The architecture, however, remained neoclassical. The painting of Madame Vergne by Antoine de Favray, completed in Constantinople in 1766, was the last great work in this hybrid mode.

During the 1870s, the French artist Charles Landelle, whose painting *Peasant Woman* (Fig. 2) had enjoyed great success when it was exhibited in 1866, was asked to paint not only exact copies of that painting but also further pictures of women dressed in Egyptian fashion. One of those women was the Marquise de Laubespain, who had travelled to Egypt many years before.³ The pattern is instructive: by the 1870s, the demand for an idealised, costumed, frequently anonymous “oriental” woman had become so well-established that she had effectively been turned into a portrait genre — a face into which any patron could be inserted.

³For an analysis of this sort of phenomenon, see Roger Benjamin, “Post-Colonial Taste: Non-Western Markets for Western Art,” in Benjamin et al., *Orientalism: Delacroix to Klee* (Sydney: Art Gallery of New South Wales, 1997), 32–40.



Fig. 2 — Charles Landelle, Peasant Woman, oil on canvas, 1866. Landelle would later be commissioned to paint copies of this work and variations of it dressed in Egyptian fashion — the “oriental woman” reduced to a portable face.

Another purpose of this book is to recover, for English-language readers, the long history in which women painted by Middle Eastern artists were neither anonymous nor passive. Women were portrayed in ancient Egyptian art as graceful, regal creatures, signifying power and fertility. Islamic art portrayed them with subtler conventions, focusing more on modesty and spiritual symbolism than on individuating physical traits — but in both Persian miniature and Ottoman manuscript painting, female

figures appear repeatedly as queens, lovers, mystics, sufferers, and saints. Religious testimonies and mythology have had a profound impact on how women are shown in Middle Eastern art. Iconic female characters from both Christian and Islamic traditions — the Virgin Mary, Mary Magdalene, Fatima the daughter of the Prophet Muhammad, and many others — have inspired a vast number of creative interpretations. These representations frequently reflect dedication to faith, morality, and religious significance.

In addition to religious and mythological representations, Middle Eastern paintings depict women in everyday life and cultural contexts. They are shown engaging in various activities — dancing, playing musical instruments, baking bread, running errands, attending each other in childbirth, taking the air with friends. These paintings offer glimpses into the diverse roles and experiences of women in Middle Eastern societies, highlighting their contributions to the cultural fabric of their communities. As the anthropologist Jessica Winegar puts it, “Middle Eastern artists use their paintings to explore themes of identity, empowerment, and resistance, shedding light on the multifaceted lives of women in the region.”⁴

Women in Middle Eastern paintings have also been depicted in historical and political contexts. Paintings of royal courts, harem scenes, or scenes of political power often feature women as significant figures, reflecting the complex dynamics of gender, power, and societal structure. These portrayals offer insights into the roles and influence of women within the political and social architectures of their times — and they remind us that the harem, far from being merely a fantasy of European male painters, was also a real institution within which real women exercised real authority

⁴Jessica Winegar, *Creative Reckonings: The Politics of Art and Culture in Contemporary Egypt* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2006).

over real budgets, real household economies, and, occasionally, real political coups.

Contemporary Middle Eastern art has brought new perspectives and new challenges to the representation of women. Women artists, in particular, have engaged actively with gender issues, exploring themes of identity, agency, and cultural expectation. They have redefined the portrayal of women by subverting traditional stereotypes, reclaiming their narratives, and highlighting the diverse experiences of women in the region. Some of them have done so from inside the region; many of them — for reasons of war, censorship, or personal choice — have done so from a diaspora that now stretches from Brooklyn to Berlin, Paris to Toronto, Istanbul to São Paulo.

Another challenge this book takes up is the exploration of gender and sexuality in images of the Middle East. This is a vibrant and evolving conversation that contributes to our understanding of the region's rich cultural heritage, its ongoing transformation, and its participation in a wider global discourse on the politics of bodies. By delving into this multifaceted topic, researchers can uncover hidden histories, challenge stereotypes, and contribute to a more nuanced and broader appreciation of Middle Eastern art and society. The simple act of including queer Middle Eastern artists in a survey such as this — Taner Ceylan, RIDIKKULUZ, Alireza Shojaian, Farida Abu Aouf, among others — has political stakes. They will be discussed in detail in Chapter 7.

1.2 Germination of the research

There are several motives for studying how women are depicted in Middle Eastern painting, and they are worth naming at the outset. The first is an understanding of the crucial function that art plays in shaping societal perceptions, conventions, and values. Scholars and art historians have

long highlighted the effect that visual tradition has on how we see gender dynamics — and on the corresponding question of how the visual record produces, rather than merely records, the social meaning of being a woman.

Second, professionals are now seriously examining how women are portrayed in art from all nations and eras, the Middle East included, in the context of the growing field of feminist art history and gender studies. This multidisciplinary method aims to analyse how innovative representations establish, contest, or perpetuate gender identities and power dynamics. The watershed for English-language art history was Linda Nochlin's 1971 essay "Why Have There Been No Great Women Artists?" — an essay whose answer was that the question itself was wrong. The infrastructures of art-making (academies, patronage networks, exhibition spaces) had been organised to ensure that there could not be such artists. The same insight, *mutatis mutandis*, applies to the Middle East: the question is not why so few "great" Middle Eastern women painters appear in standard surveys, but how those surveys have been constructed to make their presence statistically improbable.

The exploration of women's history and contributions in various fields has shed light on the often-neglected narratives of women in the arts. Researchers have recognised the need to uncover and analyse the experiences and representations of women artists, patrons, and subjects in Middle Eastern paintings. The foundational survey on this front remains Wijdan Ali's catalogue *Breaking the Veils: Women Artists from the Islamic World* (2002), which gathered work by more than fifty women painters from across the region. Subsequent contributions by Salwa Mikdadi, Nada Shabout, Anneka Lenssen, Sarah Rogers, and Suheyla Takesh have steadily filled in the gaps.

In recent years there has also been a growing awareness of the need to challenge stereotypes and misconceptions surrounding Middle Eastern cultures and societies. Examining the representation of women in Middle Eastern paintings allows for a deeper understanding of the complexities, diversities, and lived experiences of women within this cultural context. The most concrete index of that recognition is institutional: the Sharjah Art Foundation's repeated inclusion of regional women artists in its biennials, the Mathaf Arab Museum of Modern Art's ongoing acquisition of works by women, and the rise of women-led art spaces (Townhouse in Cairo, Ashkal Alwan in Beirut, Darat al Funun in Amman) which have produced an entire generation of regional artists, curators, and critics.

The need to disprove established theories, bridge information gaps, and offer a more nuanced view of women's roles, agency, and contributions within the field of art has sparked research on the depiction of women in Middle Eastern paintings. Researchers want to understand the historical, social, cultural, and political influences that have affected how women have been represented and how their roles have changed in Middle Eastern countries. To do this, they examine the visual imagery, symbolism, and narratives presented in these artworks. The book that follows is one such examination.

1.3 Defining the “Middle East” in art history

Before going further it is worth dwelling on the geographical and conceptual unit that organises this book. The “Middle East” is a phrase of late-nineteenth-century Anglo-American coinage; it spread through diplomatic, military, and academic usage in the early twentieth century. The phrase carries with it the assumptions of the Anglo-American observer who is, definitionally, situated to the west of the region in question. Most of the people I describe as “Middle Eastern” in this book would not, before

1945, have thought of themselves in those terms. They would have used Ottoman, Arab, Persian, Egyptian, Levantine, Maghrebi, Anatolian, or simply local categories.

Why retain the phrase, then? Because, for better or worse, the international art market, the major museums, and the existing English-language scholarship use it. To refuse it altogether would be to make this book impossible to find. I use it descriptively — to designate the broad band of territory running from Morocco in the west to Iran in the east, including Turkey to the north and the Arabian Peninsula to the south, and including Palestine — while remaining alert to its limitations. Where a different unit of analysis is more useful, I will reach for it: “Persianate” when discussing the long shadow of Iranian aesthetics across South and Central Asia; “Ottoman” when discussing artistic exchanges within the empire that spanned three continents; “Mediterranean” when focusing on the artistic crossings between, say, Cairo, Tunis, Marseille, and Naples; “diasporic” when artists work principally outside their countries of origin.

It is also worth noting how very recent the institutional self-organisation of “Middle Eastern art” is. The first museum dedicated specifically to modern Arab art — the Mathaf Arab Museum of Modern Art in Doha — opened only in 2010. The Sharjah Biennial, now one of the most influential platforms for contemporary art from the region, was founded in 1993 and only began to attract sustained international attention in the mid-2000s. Most of the artists discussed in the second half of this book have therefore matured in an art world that, until very recently, did not yet exist. Their generation has had to invent its own institutions even as it makes its work — a doubled labour that is felt, often, in the work itself.

1.4 Purpose of and need for the study

The study of the representation of women in Middle Eastern paintings serves several purposes and addresses several needs. It contributes to cultural understanding by delving into the diverse traditions, values, and beliefs within the region. By analysing the portrayal of women, it offers insights into their roles, identities, and experiences throughout history, providing a deeper understanding of Middle Eastern societies than the bullet points of any news cycle.

The research also contributes to gender analysis, examining power dynamics and societal norms. It explores how women are represented in art, shedding light on their agency, sexuality, and identities. By critically examining these representations, researchers can uncover underlying social and cultural constructs related to gender. Studying the representation of women in Middle Eastern paintings allows for the appreciation of women artists and their contributions: it helps to bring recognition to those who may have been marginalised or overlooked in traditional art-historical narratives. By acknowledging and celebrating their creative expressions, the research highlights the artistic achievements of women in the Middle East.

It contributes, too, to a broader societal discourse by challenging biases, stereotypes, and misconceptions. Examining the representation of women prompts discussions on gender equality, women's rights, and social justice within the Middle Eastern context. This research encourages a critical examination of societal attitudes and norms, fostering a more inclusive and equitable dialogue. Some statistics will help to fix the stakes. According to the Arab Barometer's 2021–22 wave, women's labour-force participation across the region averaged 19 per cent — the lowest of any world region — even as women's share of tertiary-education enrolments exceeded that of men in most Arab countries. The visual culture of a

society is not unrelated to such numbers; it both reflects and helps to produce them.

Moreover, the study recognises the intersectionality of gender with other social categories such as religion, ethnicity, class, and nationality. It explores how these intersecting identities influence the representation of women in art and their lived experiences in the Middle East. By considering these multiple dimensions, the research provides a more comprehensive understanding of women's experiences and challenges stereotypes associated with Middle Eastern women — that they are uniformly Muslim (they are not), uniformly veiled (they are not), uniformly oppressed (they are not), or uniformly protected (they are not). The Middle East contains Christian, Jewish, Druze, Yazidi, Bahá'í, Mandaean, and Zoroastrian women alongside Muslim ones, and an art-historical narrative that flattens these distinctions has missed something essential about its own subject.

The prejudiced and constrained representation of women in popular culture creates an urgent need for research into how women are portrayed in Middle Eastern art. By conducting this study, I hope to balance the scales, dispel myths, and provide a more complex and comprehensive view of the diversity, agency, and contributions of women in the Middle Eastern artistic and cultural heritage.

1.5 Conceptualising art, identity, and belonging

A fascinating backdrop for examining the complex interrelationships between art, identity, and belonging is provided by the depiction of women in Middle Eastern paintings. Visual art has the ability to shape both individual and group identities — and a person's sense of belonging within a particular social and cultural context.

Understanding the representation of women in Middle Eastern art can help us better understand how identity is constructed, negotiated, and how difficult belonging can be there. People and communities can express their identities, question cultural conventions, and make their presence felt through art. Middle Eastern paintings of women depict the many facets of identity — gender, religion, race, sociocultural background, region, language, age, marital status, and class. These pieces of art illustrate women as creators of their own identities, highlighting their social positions, experiences, and goals.

Moreover, the representation of women in Middle Eastern paintings is deeply intertwined with notions of belonging. Artworks often reflect cultural and social values, traditions, and histories that shape a sense of belonging to a particular community or cultural heritage. By visually depicting women engaged in various aspects of everyday life, religious practice, or communal celebration, these paintings create a visual narrative of shared experience and communal belonging.

However, the portrayal of women in Middle Eastern art is not just a reflection of the ideas or cultural beliefs of the artists. It also provides a forum for discussion and disagreement. By challenging prevailing myths and prejudices, women are given the chance to recover their identities, defy social norms, and express their presence in public space. Women can question and reinvent their positions, fight for their rights, and create new stories of identity and belonging through artistic expression.

This portrayal can also be viewed as a means of empowerment and resistance. It gives women a way to take back their agency and fight against repressive structures. In their exploration of resilience, strength, and beauty, artists show women as leaders in their communities — strong and influential. These pieces of art present alternate narratives that

honour the accomplishments of women, go against gender stereotypes, and promote societal change.

Conceptualising art, identity, and belonging in the context of the representation of women in Middle Eastern paintings means acknowledging the complex interplay between artistic expression, individual and collective identity, and the sense of belonging within diverse cultural and social contexts. It recognises the power of art to shape and redefine identities, challenge societal norms, and foster a sense of belonging and connection within communities. By critically examining these artworks, we can gain a deeper understanding of the nuanced relationships between art, identity, and belonging in the Middle Eastern context.

1.6 Methods and methodological approaches

The study of the representation of women in Middle Eastern paintings can be approached using various methods and methodological frameworks. In this book, I have used several in combination, drawing on the toolkit of art history, the categories of gender studies, and the practical experience of conducting field interviews with living artists.

Visual analysis. The meanings and implications of artworks are deduced by carefully evaluating their visual components — composition, colour, symbolism, gesture, gaze, and facial expression. Through such analysis I have investigated how women are portrayed, the stories that are told about them, and the cultural symbols that are used. The most basic question to ask of any image of a woman is: where is she standing, where are her eyes, who is being addressed, and who is being excluded?

Iconographic analysis. The study of symbols and their significance in art — the discipline christened by Erwin Panofsky and Aby Warburg — can be

used to decipher the symbolic language present in Middle Eastern paintings. This technique aids in exposing subliminal messages, cultural allusions, and religious symbolism associated with female depiction. The veil, the pomegranate, the mirror, the lamp, the lattice screen (mashrabiya), the spindle: each carries a long iconographic history that can be unpacked.

Comparative analysis. Within the Middle East, I have compared works of art from various eras, locations, and artistic traditions. With this strategy it is possible to spot trends, modifications, and impacts in the representation of women over time. Where a Persian seventeenth-century miniature and an Egyptian twentieth-century oil painting share a common motif — the female figure beneath a tree, for example, an iconography that goes back to Mesopotamian seal cylinders — the comparative method allows us to read the latter as a knowing recital of the former.

Historical research. Archival work, the consultation of old records, and the study of the socio-political settings in which the artworks were produced have been essential. By placing artworks within their historical contexts, the social, cultural, and religious influences that shaped how women were shown can be reconstructed. Travel narratives by Lady Mary Wortley Montagu (the British ambassador's wife in early-eighteenth-century Constantinople), Sophia Lane Poole (in 1840s Cairo), and Gertrude Bell (in early-twentieth-century Mesopotamia) have proven especially helpful, as has the more recent flood of monographs from the AKPIA, Aga Khan, and Mathaf research programmes.

Feminist analysis. When studying Middle Eastern paintings, I analyse gender dynamics, power relations, and the agency of women critically by drawing on a feminist toolkit. This strategy challenges patriarchal assumptions, investigates female subjectivity, and looks at how women's

experiences and viewpoints are portrayed in art. The classics of the feminist art-historical canon — Nochlin, Pollock, Mulvey, Lippard, Doane — sit on my desk alongside more recent regionally focused work by Fatema Mernissi, Nawal El Saadawi, Nadia Yaqub, Anneka Lenssen, and Hanan Toukan.

Postcolonial and decolonial analysis. Edward Said's *Orientalism* (1978) made it impossible, after its publication, to read European paintings of the Middle East as innocent records of fact. The book's argument — that European representations of the East are systematically constituted in the service of colonial power — has been refined and contested by Ali Behdad, Linda Nochlin, John MacKenzie, and others, but it remains, with all its limitations, the indispensable starting point. I extend the analysis backwards into the eighteenth century and forwards into the contemporary period, where the categories of Orient and Occident continue to do quiet ideological work even when the painters themselves no longer use the words.

What follows is, finally, less a single method than a disciplined eclecticism. The materials are too various, the histories too long, the politics too live, for any one approach to do them justice. I have therefore tried to listen to the paintings, in something like the way that one listens to people — patiently, with respect, and with the willingness to let one's assumptions be revised.

CHAPTER TWO

Iconography of Women in Religious Painting



Christian, Jewish, and Islamic Visions

2.1 Introduction

The historical representation of women in Middle Eastern paintings examines how women have been depicted in artworks throughout the region's long history. It encompasses a wide range of subjects, including religious iconography, courtly scenes, and depictions of everyday life. Religious art often features women as central figures in Middle Eastern paintings, drawn from a variety of faiths. Christian art may depict the Virgin Mary or other female saints; Islamic art may portray figures such as Fatima, the daughter of the Prophet Muhammad; Jewish art may depict Sarah, Rebecca, Rachel, Esther, or the personification of the Sabbath. These representations often highlight the virtues and spiritual significance of these women, emphasising their purity, devotion, or role within the religious narrative — and they have, between them, supplied the visual vocabulary by which a great many other paintings of women have been read.

In courtly scenes and portraits, women are often depicted as symbols of beauty, elegance, and social status. These artworks may feature royal

women, princesses, or women from wealthy and influential families. Such representations can reflect the ideals of the era, showcasing the refinement associated with the ruling elite. They provide insights into the lives and roles of women within elite circles, while also demonstrating the artistic skills of the painters. Depictions of women in everyday life offer glimpses into the diverse experiences of women from different social classes and regions. These artworks often depict women engaged in domestic tasks, child-rearing, and social interactions. They can showcase the roles and responsibilities of women within their communities, providing insights into their daily lives and the cultural practices prevalent at the time.

The historical representation of women in Middle Eastern paintings reflects the values, beliefs, and social dynamics of the periods in which they were created. They provide glimpses into the diverse roles, identities, and experiences of women across different contexts and time periods. Exploring these artworks allows for a deeper understanding of the historical, cultural, and societal contexts in which women lived and the ways in which they were visually represented. The chapter that follows is divided by religion — Christian, Jewish, Islamic — but readers should bear in mind that the boundaries between these traditions in the Middle East have always been more porous than the standard surveys suggest. A Christian painter in seventeenth-century Aleppo could quote a Persian miniature; a Jewish printmaker in early-twentieth-century Jaffa could borrow from Ottoman calligraphy; a contemporary Muslim artist in Cairo can claim Coptic icon painting as part of her own visual genealogy. Religion has shaped these images, but it has not enclosed them.

2.2 Iconography of women in Christian religious art

Iconography refers to the representation and symbolism of female figures in artworks that hold religious or spiritual significance. It encompasses various traditions, including Christian, Islamic, Jewish, and others. In Christian religious art, women are often depicted as significant figures in biblical narratives. Stefanie Schäfer-Bossert observes that the female images that survived from medieval to early-modern periods broadly represented two opposite types: first was Eve, signifying the essence of woman as inferior to man because of her seductiveness and her susceptibility to temptation; second was Mary — in reality, three Marys: the mother of Christ, Mary Magdalene, and Mary of Bethany — who appeared as icons of humility, the opposites of Eve, often kneeling before the Lord or standing under His cross.

The *Madonna Litta* (Fig. 3) — long attributed to Leonardo da Vinci and now generally given to Leonardo and his workshop — is one of the iconic Renaissance paintings of the Madonna and Child, depicting the Virgin Mary holding the infant Jesus.⁵ The image showcases Mary as a tender, nurturing mother, often portrayed with a serene expression and a gentle touch. She is often depicted wearing a blue robe, symbolising her purity and divine connection. The blue itself was, in the late medieval and Renaissance imagination, a colour of imported pigment — ultramarine, made from lapis lazuli mined in what is now Afghanistan. The most expensive colour on a Renaissance painter's palette was, by literal geological fact, an Asian colour. Maryam, the Arabic name for Mary, was

⁵On the disputed attribution of the *Madonna Litta* to Leonardo and his workshop, see Carmen C. Bambach, *Leonardo da Vinci Rediscovered* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2019), vol. 2, 253–62.

wrapped, on the canvases that European altarpieces show us, in a literal piece of the East.



Fig. 3 — Leonardo da Vinci and workshop, Madonna Litta, c. 1481–1495, Hermitage Museum, St Petersburg. The blue of the Virgin’s robe was made from ultramarine, a pigment imported from what is now Afghanistan.

Female saints and biblical heroines are also depicted in religious art. They include Saint Catherine, Saint Cecilia, Mary Magdalene, the Virgin of Sorrows, and many others, each with her own iconography and symbolism. These depictions often emphasise the virtues, martyrdom, or exemplary lives of these women, providing role models for believers and

showcasing their devotion and faith. In the eastern Christian traditions of the Middle East — Greek Orthodox, Antiochian Orthodox, Coptic, Armenian, Maronite, Melkite — the iconography is older still, and the formal vocabulary is closer to Byzantium than to Florence.

The Coptic icons of Egypt, for example, present the Virgin and the female saints with the wide, hieratic eyes that mark Byzantine iconography, but with a softness of cheek and lip that comes specifically from late-antique Egyptian funerary portraiture (the so-called Fayum portraits). The line from the second-century Fayum mummy portraits to the contemporary Coptic icons painted by Isaac Fanous (1919–2007) and his school of the “Coptic neo-iconography” is unbroken — a Christian Middle Eastern tradition of female imagery that has been continuously productive for nearly two millennia.



Fig. 4 — Dieric Bouts, The Last Supper (centre panel), c. 1464–1468. Bouts inserts a single woman — by some readings the Magdalen, by others a kitchen maid — at the threshold of the upper room: a small, characteristic gesture of admitting the female witness to a scene that the Gospels reserve for men.

Dieric Bouts's *Last Supper*, painted in mid-fifteenth-century Leuven, is in this respect typical of a long iconographic strategy: Christ is at the centre, surrounded by the twelve, but at the threshold of the upper room a small female figure appears. By some readings she is Mary Magdalene, who is herself the most consistently re-imagined female figure in Western art — penitent, prophet, apostle, courtesan, mystic, by turns. By other readings she is simply a kitchen maid, the woman who sets the table, and her quiet presence is the painter's acknowledgment that the most ostensibly all-male scene of Christian iconography rests, at its base, on the labour of women.

Raphael's *Sistine Madonna* (Fig. 5) — painted in 1513–14 for the Benedictine church of San Sisto in Piacenza and later sold to Augustus III of Saxony in 1754, when it became one of the most-reproduced images in European visual culture — features the Virgin Mary holding the infant Jesus, accompanied by Saint Sixtus and Saint Barbara. The painting is characterised by its tender portrayal of Mary, with her gaze directed towards the viewer, conveying a sense of compassion and divine grace. Two famously distracted putti lean on the parapet at the bottom of the picture; their afterlife as detachable greeting-card decorations testifies to the strange way images can become unmoored from the iconographic programme that produced them.



Fig. 5 — Raphael, The Sistine Madonna, c. 1513–1514, Gemäldegalerie Alte Meister, Dresden. Mary’s gaze meets the viewer’s — an unusually direct address that has helped make the image one of the most reproduced in European art.

In a Middle Eastern context the figure of the Virgin acquires further specific meaning. She is, after all, the mother of an Aramaic-speaking Levantine Jew. The shrines associated with Mary at Saidnaya in Syria, at Harissa in Lebanon, at the Sanctuary of Our Lady of Lebanon, and at the Coptic monasteries of Wadi al-Natrun draw both Christian and Muslim pilgrims. Her name appears in the Qur’an more often than in the New Testament. To paint Mary, in the Middle East, has always been to paint a

woman who belongs to several traditions at once — and the visual evidence of that pluralism is older than any modern theology of interfaith dialogue.

2.3 *The Virgin in the Eastern Mediterranean*

Long before the standardised Western Madonna, the Eastern Mediterranean produced its own line of female religious imagery. The cult of the Theotokos — “the God-bearer” — was elaborated theologically at the Council of Ephesus in 431 CE and given visual form in a series of Byzantine icon types: the Hodegetria, in which Mary points with her right hand to the infant Christ; the Eleousa, in which mother and son press cheek to cheek; the Galaktotrophousa, in which Mary nurses the child; and the Glykophilousa, in which the child plays with his mother’s veil.

Each of these types travelled across the Mediterranean. The Hodegetria appears in the eleventh-century mosaic at Hosios Loukas in Greece, in the Coptic monasteries of Egypt, in the Armenian manuscripts produced at the scriptoria of Cilicia, and — finally — in the Italian panel paintings of Cimabue, Duccio, and the early Sienese masters. The line that runs from the Theotokos of Vladimir (an early-twelfth-century Constantinopolitan panel taken to Russia in 1131) to Raphael’s Sistine Madonna can be drawn without leaving the eastern Mediterranean.

The Galaktotrophousa — the nursing Mary — is particularly interesting in Middle Eastern Christian art. In a culture in which the public exposure of the female body had been heavily regulated for at least a millennium before Christianity, the image of Mary feeding the child Christ from her bared breast made a theological point about the Incarnation: the divine had taken on flesh real enough to need ordinary nourishment. The same iconography was preserved, with characteristic adaptations, in the Coptic, Ethiopian, and Syriac traditions, and a fine fourteenth-century

Galaktotrophousa survives at the Monastery of Saint Anthony in the Egyptian desert.

What is striking, comparing this long Eastern Mediterranean tradition to its Western counterpart, is how comparatively unsentimental the Eastern Mary tends to be. The Western Madonna of the late Middle Ages and the Renaissance is increasingly individualised — she has facial features that resemble the painter's wife or patron's daughter, she occupies plausible domestic interiors, she radiates motherly warmth in a vernacular register. The Eastern icon, by contrast, retains a hieratic stillness. The Theotokos of Sinai is monumental, otherworldly, and addresses the viewer with the same level of authority as a Pantocrator. Whatever else the Eastern Christian tradition does to its female figures, it does not domesticate them.

2.4 Jewish religious iconography

In Jewish religious art, depictions of women often revolve around biblical stories and heroines. These artworks may portray figures such as Sarah, Rebecca, Rachel, Esther, Judith, Hannah, or Deborah. Each figure carries unique symbolism and significance within Jewish religious and cultural traditions, highlighting qualities such as faith, righteousness, bravery, leadership, or the cunning required to keep a covenant alive in inhospitable circumstances.

Like Ephraim Moses Lilien's "The Sabbath Queen," painted around 1900 (Fig. 9), this tradition has often allegorised femininity itself: the Shabbat is feminised in classical Jewish liturgy as a queen and a bride, and Lilien's engraving makes the personification literal. A woman sits in the middle of the frame, holding a decorated Torah scroll. The picture's caption appears at the bottom in German — Sabbath der Sabbath (Sabbath of Sabbaths) — and it portrays the Shabbat Queen with her hair in a long braid and a

crown on her head. Her sleeveless, full-length dress contains the letters of the Hebrew alphabet, while the bottom of her dress finishes with a bold black line and a white panel, possibly imitating a tallit (prayer shawl) typically worn on Shabbat. The Shabbat Queen sits in a throne that displays a large Star of David behind her head. The throne is surrounded by trees bearing fruit, and a forest can be seen in the background. There is a small dove on the top of her crown, representing the peace that Shabbat and the Shabbat Queen bring after six weekdays. The tones of the trees suggest that the sun is setting — implying the arrival of Shabbat.



Fig. 9 — Ephraim Moses Lilien, The Sabbath Queen, early twentieth century. The Hebrew letters that line the figure's dress dissolve the boundary between calligraphy, costume, and theology.

The notion of the Shabbat Queen stems from the kabbalistic idea of Shabbat as the spiritual queen of the week, and during the Friday-night Kabbalat Shabbat service it is customary to sing *Lecha Dodi*, a sixteenth-century liturgical hymn which welcomes Shabbat and the Shabbat Bride or Queen.⁶ Lilien's achievement, in this image, is to give a kabbalistic abstraction the body of a young woman without thereby reducing the abstraction to mere illustration. The dove of Shabbat peace, the Star of David, and the orchard around the throne all do double duty as decorative motifs and theological signs.

Lilien himself, born in Drohobych in Galicia in 1874 and active in Berlin, Vienna, and Jerusalem, was the first major Jewish artist to identify with the Zionist movement, and his designs — including the official postcards of the Fifth Zionist Congress at Basel in 1901 — circulated widely. His Sabbath Queen belongs to a moment in which a self-consciously modern Jewish art was being invented, often by artists trained in the secessionist studios of Central Europe but reaching back to a cultural archive in which the female personification of holiness was already old.

The Mizrahi and Sephardi Jewish traditions of the Middle East and the Maghreb developed their own visual cultures of femininity. The illustrated marriage contracts (ketubot) of eighteenth- and nineteenth-century Iran, Iraq, Yemen, and Morocco use the visual conventions of contemporaneous Islamic miniature painting — gold leaf, floral arabesque, paired birds, calligraphic borders — to frame the legally

⁶This description draws on the website of the National Library of Israel, <https://web.nli.org.il> (consulted 2023). The *Lecha Dodi* was composed by the kabbalist Shlomo Halevi Alkabetz in sixteenth-century Safed.

enforceable promises that Jewish husbands made to Jewish wives. The Yemeni ketubot are particularly intricate, and the figure of the bride is sometimes alluded to (rarely depicted) at the centre of an architectural frame whose visual logic is taken directly from the page layouts of the Qur'ans being copied in the same workshops two streets away.

2.5 Women in Islamic religious imagery

In Islamic religious art, female figures are often represented in illuminated manuscripts, miniature paintings, and calligraphy. The art of Persian and Ottoman miniature painting frequently includes women, particularly in illustrations of stories and poems. Women may be depicted in scenes from Islamic history or folklore, as well as in spiritual or mystical contexts. In some cases calligraphy may also incorporate the names of significant women in Islam, such as the Prophet Muhammad's daughter Fatima or his wife Khadija and Aisha. As Fatema Mernissi famously observed, "it's not the physical but the ideological veils of misunderstanding that are at issue" — and the absence of overt female figural imagery in many strands of Islamic religious art has been read by Western viewers far too readily as the absence of women altogether.

Islamic art has a long tradition of avoiding the overt depiction of women — and other human beings — in explicitly religious settings. This custom has its roots in aniconism, the theological caution against the representation of living things, intended to reduce the possibility of idolatry or the worship of objects. As a result, Islamic religious art frequently concentrates on geometric pattern, floral motif, and calligraphy, rather than on the depiction of human figures. But aniconism is not, and never was, the whole story. Outside the explicitly religious frame — in court manuscripts, in illustrated histories and romances, on

the walls of aristocratic palaces — women appear in considerable variety: as queens, lovers, warriors, mystics, wet-nurses, dancers, gardeners.

Persian miniature painting in particular elaborated a distinctive iconography of femininity. The lovers Layla and Majnun, drawn from Nizami Ganjavi's twelfth-century Persian rendering of an older Arabic legend, recur in countless illustrations across the Timurid, Safavid, and Qajar centuries. Layla is shown sometimes as a child (she falls in love with Majnun in school), sometimes as a bride, sometimes as the figure who appears, beatifically, to her demented lover in the wilderness. The narrative gives painters the chance to construct an iconography of feminine reserve that is simultaneously erotic and religious — Layla is the beloved who, like the Sufi's God, withdraws to draw the lover after her.



Fig. 6 — Osman Hamdi Bey, The Courtyard of the Women (variant title), late nineteenth century. Hamdi Bey was the first Turkish artist to paint full figures in oil; his interiors are filled with the architectural and decorative detail that he documented as the inaugural director of the Imperial Museum.

In the late Ottoman period, Osman Hamdi Bey (1842–1910) was the first Turkish artist to make figural oil painting a sustained personal practice. In his canvases, architectural and decorative detail accumulates with a quiet pressure: tiles, calligraphy, lattice, prayer rug, candlestick, copper basin. He frequently appears as a male figure within the composition, and many of his paintings feature women engaged in various activities — reading, conversing, preparing for an outing, mending. The “Mihrab” painting (1901, now in the collection of the Pera Museum) shows a woman seated on a pile of holy books inside a mosque niche, her dress richly embroidered, a Qur’an open at her feet — an image whose theological and gender politics scholars are still arguing about.

Mihri Müşfik Hanım (1886–1954) was a prominent Turkish artist and one of the first female painters in Turkey. Born in Istanbul, she received her education in the arts at the Istanbul Academy of Fine Arts, where she studied under renowned Turkish painters and instructors. While education for girls in any topic was limited to a very small group of families in Turkey — and equally rare was the number of young Turkish women who would have had the opportunity to study in Europe — Mihri Hanım had just that opportunity. Her work helped pave the way for future generations of women artists and played a vital role in the development of Turkish modern art.



Fig. 7 — Mihri Müşfik Hanım, Portrait of Mevsume Yalçın. Mihri's neoclassical interior, lit from the left, places her sitter in a register of European bourgeois portraiture — but her sitter is a Turkish woman, and the painter is one of the first of her generation.

In this artwork, Mihri Hanım depicts Mevsume Hanım — the wife of journalist Hüseyin Cahit Yalçın — at the centre of the composition, in a French neoclassical-style armchair, her right elbow resting on the chair's edge in a self-assured pose. The lilac dress, the half-glimpsed seats opening like a door onto a brighter saloon, the fireplace, clock, and trinkets behind the model, the gold-leafed chair frames, the eye-catching red and black carpet on the floor — all of this advertises both the household's wealth and the painter's technical command. The two seats glimpsed at

the front of the picture have the effect of a doorway opening to a saloon illuminated by light from the left, and the statue completing the décor is part of the same Europeanising programme.



Fig. 8 — Mihri Müşfik Hanım, Letta Asım, Wife of Foreign Minister Asım Bey, Going to the Ball, 1911–12. The pink-and-lilac palette, the unfinished right arm, and the confident gaze together index the painter’s decision to leave the picture at exactly the level of finish she wanted.

Mihri Hanım also painted Letta Hanım, the Austrian wife of Foreign Minister Asım Pasha, about to leave for the ball at the Sofia embassy. The painting was studied from a photograph; Mihri depicted Letta Hanım in full length from the front. The crown in the model's bun, the fan in her hand, the ribbons and flowers adorning her dress, were made with comfortable brushstrokes and quick sleight of hand; the model's right arm was left, deliberately, with a few brush-strokes before being completed. The dress, with its moving lines, is dominated by pink and lilac. A confident and distinguished expression of the beauty of the model's face was successfully achieved by laying down widely spaced scans of brown and purple tones in the background. After her divorce, Mihri left Istanbul to live and teach in Rome, then in New York; she died in poverty in 1954, and her grave was forgotten until Turkish art historians located it in the 1990s. The trajectory is, in its way, characteristic of the first generation of regional women painters: pioneering in the local context, half-erased in the global one.

The discussion above takes the standard religious frames — Christian, Jewish, Islamic — but it is worth restating, as the chapter closes, that those frames are themselves historical constructions. A great many Middle Eastern artists, then and now, have moved freely between them. The Lebanese-Egyptian painter Georges Cyr (1880–1964) was Catholic; the Iraqi painter Hafidh al-Droubi (1914–1991), who taught a generation of Iraqi women artists, was Muslim; the Iranian-American Shirin Neshat (b. 1957), whose practice will be discussed at length in Chapter 6, treats Shi'a iconography as part of her aesthetic vocabulary while keeping a firm critical distance from any single doctrinal reading. Religious art uses the imagery of women to convey and reaffirm religious narratives, teachings, and ideals. It offers pictures of significant people and events, encouraging adoration and a closer relationship with the divine. Religious art may express cultural, social, and theological viewpoints on femininity,

spirituality, and the place of women in particular religious traditions through its representation of women — but it also provides resources that women artists, in turn, have used to make their own claims, in their own languages, to meanings that the original traditions did not always anticipate.

CHAPTER THREE

Women in Courtly Scenes and Portraits



From the Ottoman Court to the Modern Egyptian Studio

3.1 The aristocratic eye

The aristocratic or royal courts frequently shaped how women were portrayed in the great age of European and Middle Eastern court painting between the seventeenth and the twentieth centuries. These paintings feature affluent women — princesses, noblewomen, members of the ruling class — in sumptuous settings adorned with ornate decoration, exquisite attire, and opulent furnishings. They are frequently depicted partaking in leisure pursuits like music, dance, poetry, or game-playing. These scenes try to capture the elegance, grace, and sophistication of courtly culture, but they do something else as well: they ratify the legitimacy of dynastic power. To paint the women of a court was, very often, to paint the dynasty's confidence in itself.



Fig. 10 — Diego Velázquez, Las Meninas, oil on canvas, 318 × 276 cm, 1656, Museo del Prado, Madrid. The painting's self-reflexive structure has fascinated philosophers from Foucault to Searle: who, exactly, is the implied subject of this picture?

One of the most well-known paintings of the early modern court is *Las Meninas* by Diego Velázquez (1656). The figure-shapes in the mirror in the background ought to resemble the figures standing in the space in front of the picture plane, who are in turn supposedly being depicted by the (depicted) painter on the canvas facing away from the picture plane. But perspectively, the figures and shapes in the mirror specifically denote what we, the implied viewers, see reflected in the mirror — whatever it is — while the figure-shapes that the painter is seemingly painting on the canvas, though they should closely resemble that reflection, do not

specifically denote it but rather what the painter sees right in front of him.⁷ This iconic painting depicts the Spanish Infanta Margarita surrounded by her attendants and courtiers. The composition offers a glimpse into the opulent court life and highlights the status and presence of the young princess as the focal point of the painting — and Michel Foucault’s reading of *Las Meninas* in *The Order of Things* (1966) made it the canonical case for the philosophical analysis of how images construct, rather than merely record, their subjects.

Why begin a chapter on courtly women in the Middle East with a Spanish painting? Because Velázquez worked in a court that, two generations earlier, had still been negotiating with the Ottomans for control of the Mediterranean, and the visual conventions of European court portraiture in the seventeenth century — the framing devices, the use of mirrors and dwarves, the play with the relative status of viewer and viewed — became part of the international stock from which both European and Middle Eastern painters would eventually draw. The Ottoman court itself produced its own great age of figural painting in roughly the same period, in a medium (illuminated manuscript) that has come down to us less through grand single canvases than through accumulations of folios, but the conceptual sophistication is comparable.

⁷Velázquez painted directly, without preparatory drawing, in the *alla prima* technique. Foucault’s reading of *Las Meninas* opens *The Order of Things* (1966); for an alternative analysis, see John Searle, “*Las Meninas* and the Paradoxes of Pictorial Representation,” *Critical Inquiry* 6, no. 3 (1980): 477–88.



Fig. 11 — Jan van Eyck, The Arnolfini Portrait, oil on oak, 82.2 × 60 cm, 1434, National Gallery, London. The hand of the wife — held in a gesture variously read as fidelity, fertility, or self-presentation — has been the subject of more than five hundred years of art-historical interpretation.

Another example is *The Arnolfini Portrait* by Jan van Eyck (1434), the famous double portrait of Giovanni di Nicolao Arnolfini and his wife. While the painting portrays a wealthy couple, it also highlights the role and presence of the wife, who is depicted in elegant attire and holds her hand in a gesture that has been variously read as one of modesty, fidelity, or fertility. The convex mirror at the back of the room reflects two further

figures, sometimes identified as the painter and a witness — an additional reminder that the early modern portrait was always also a legal document, a record of social status, and a self-conscious meditation on the act of seeing.

3.2 Mahmoud Said and the Egyptian portrait

One of the painters who portrayed the Middle East from within is Mahmoud Said (1897–1964). He was born in Alexandria into one of the most prominent families in Egypt — his sister Saafia would marry King Farouk's grandfather, making him uncle to a queen — and never worked as a professional artist, since he was, by training and profession, a lawyer. However, his paintings of the cosmopolitan community of his northern port city are central to the history of modern art in Egypt, and he attracted increasing public attention in his later years. The Egyptian Surrealist movement adopted Said as an honorary member and included his work in their first exhibition, selecting his famous painting *Woman with Golden Curls* for the cover of the exhibition catalogue in 1940. By that point Said had become an increasingly respected member of the Egyptian art community, and the inauguration of the Mahmoud Said Museum in Alexandria in 2000 confirmed his place in the national canon.



Fig. 12 — Mahmoud Said, The Inauguration of the Suez Canal, 1946–47. Said’s history painting places two women in their fineries at the front of the composition, refusing the convention by which official ceremonies are remembered as a row of moustachioed men.

One of Said’s great public paintings, *The Inauguration of the Suez Canal*, captures the royal ceremony of 1869 in retrospect — Said painted it in 1946–47, eight decades after the event — and places two women in elaborate gowns at the front of the composition, claiming for them the visual centrality that the historical record has tended to deny them. The Khedive Isma’il and the Empress Eugénie of France presided over the original ceremony; Said’s painting, executed at the very moment when nationalist Egyptian politics was moving towards the 1952 revolution that would end the monarchy, redistributes attention towards the women of the court rather than its rulers.



Fig. 18 — Mahmoud Said, Woman with Golden Curls, oil on canvas, 80 × 60 cm, 1933. The painting was selected by the Egyptian Surrealists for the cover of their first exhibition catalogue in 1940.

Mahmoud Said's portraits of women focus on capturing their individual features and characteristics. These portraits emphasise the wealth, status, and beauty of the depicted women. They highlight elaborate costumes, jewellery, and hairstyles, while showcasing the artist's skill in capturing facial expressions and personality. *Woman with Golden Curls* is, in this sense, a kind of manifesto: the sitter's gaze is direct and intelligent, her green eyes lit against the dark green ground; her curls are not so much hair

as a halo of small flames; her décolleté is a frank claim that the modern Egyptian woman could be a subject of painterly desire without thereby being demeaned.



Fig. 19 — Mahmoud Said, Portrait of Mrs Sherifa Riad, oil on canvas, 70 × 35.5 cm, 1920.



Fig. 20 — Mahmoud Said, Portrait of Mr Ahmed Mazloun's Wife, oil on plywood, 76 × 59 cm, 1936.

Said's 1920 *Portrait of Mrs Sherifa Riad* is, by his own later standards, comparatively quiet: the sitter is depicted in profile, her hair pulled back, her dress dark, her gaze calm and slightly distant. Sixteen years later, in the *Portrait of Mr Ahmed Mazloun's Wife*, the language has changed entirely. The composition is frontal, the colour is keyed up, the face is held in a way that suggests both authority and self-possession. Between these two paintings sit a series of others — Said painted his sister, his nieces, his friends, his servants, the dancers and singers of cosmopolitan Alexandria

— that together constitute one of the most ambitious projects in early modern Arab portraiture. The Egyptian art historian Liliane Karnouk has described Said's portraits as "the painted equivalent of a national autobiography," and the description is exact: collectively, they produce a portrait of Egypt at the moment of its modernisation.

3.3 Other Middle Eastern modernisms

The Egyptian story is the most fully recovered, but it is not unique. In Beirut and Damascus, painters of the same generation — Khalil Saleeby (1870–1928), Daoud Corm (1852–1930), Habib Srour (1860–1938) — produced a portrait tradition that drew on European academic conventions but applied them to a distinctively Levantine clientele. In Baghdad, the brothers Faiq and Khaled Hassan opened the first Iraqi studio in the 1930s, and Lorna Selim — the Anglo-Iraqi wife of the painter and sculptor Jewad Selim — produced a series of portraits of Iraqi women in the 1950s and 1960s that documented the social transformation of the post-monarchy republic. In Tehran, the great Qajar court painter Kamal-ol-Molk (1847–1940) had already, by the turn of the twentieth century, brought the conventions of European naturalism into the Iranian royal portrait — and his pupils would teach the women painters of the next generation, Mansoureh Hosseini, Behjat Sadr, Iran Darroudi, who in turn made the modern Iranian art scene of the 1950s and 1960s.

The collective effect of this regional modernism is to puncture the myth that Middle Eastern painting was a primarily European preoccupation. Painters from the region were already inside the global conversation about portraiture, modernism, and the figure long before the international art market noticed them. The recent retrospectives — Mahmoud Said at the Institut du Monde Arabe in 2024, Saliba Douaihy at AUB Beirut in 2022, the Behjat Sadr at the Pompidou-Metz in 2023 — are

correctives to a story that has been quietly producing itself for over a century.

3.4 The Persianate court and the long history of feminine presence

Behind the modern Egyptian and Levantine portrait tradition stands a much older Persianate one. Court painting at Tabriz, Herat, Isfahan, and Shiraz between the fourteenth and the eighteenth century produced thousands of folios in which female figures appeared as central characters: the heroines of the *Shahnameh* (Roxana, Tahmineh, Sudabeh), the lovers of the *Khamsa* of Nizami (Layla, Shirin, Nushabeh), the noblewomen of the Safavid court whose names we sometimes know and sometimes do not. The miniature painters of the late Timurid school, working in Herat under the patronage of Sultan Husayn Bayqara at the end of the fifteenth century, included the great Kamal al-Din Bihzad — and recent scholarship by David Roxburgh has shown how women in those paintings are depicted with a precision of physiognomy and gesture that complicates the easy claim that Islamic art does not “individuate” its female figures.

By the Qajar period (1789–1925), Iranian court painting had absorbed European illusionistic conventions while preserving its own iconographic vocabulary. The famous “Qajar women” paintings of Mihr ‘Ali, Abu’l-Hasan Khan Ghaffari (Sani al-Mulk), and others depict young women holding fruit, flowers, or musical instruments, dressed in the long pearl-and-gold-embroidered robes of the Tehran court. Their full-length portraits, now scattered between the Sa’dabad palaces, the Hermitage, the Met, and the Louvre, constitute one of the largest single archives of feminine portraiture produced in the early modern Islamic world. The disconnect between the wealth of this archive and its near-invisibility in standard

Western surveys of nineteenth-century art is one of the indictments of the discipline itself.

3.5 Orientalism revisited: Vanmour, Gérôme, Fabbi

On the other hand, portraits served several purposes for the European Orientalists who painted Middle Eastern subjects. They documented the lives and activities of women from privileged backgrounds, offering insights — usually mediated, often inaccurate — into their roles and social positions. They reflected European ideals of courtly culture, emphasising the importance of beauty, refinement, and etiquette. These artworks often sought to convey the power and prestige of the ruling class, using women as symbols of wealth and social standing. They sold extraordinarily well in the European market, especially after the opening of the Suez Canal in 1869, and a small number of artists — Jean-Léon Gérôme, John Frederick Lewis, Eugène Fromentin, Étienne Dinet, Frederick Arthur Bridgman — built entire careers on this trade.

One of the most representative Orientalist painters is Jean-Léon Gérôme (Vesoul, 1824 – Paris, 1904). He was a French painter and sculptor in the academic style that, by the late nineteenth century, was already being challenged by the Impressionists and that he would, until his death, defend with conservative ferocity. His paintings included historical scenes, Greek mythology, Orientalism, and portraiture. Gérôme was deeply fascinated by the Orient and frequently chose Oriental women as subjects in his paintings. His works often depicted a romanticised and idealised version of the East, capturing the Western imagination of exoticism and sensuality.



Fig. 16 — Jean-Léon Gérôme, Woman of Constantinople, oil on canvas, 40.5 × 32 cm, 1876. Gérôme's precision in costume detail is matched by an equally precise commercial calculation: the painting was made for a European buyer, not for an Ottoman one.

In *Woman of Constantinople*, Gérôme presents a female figure portrait dressed in traditional Ottoman attire, capturing the intricate details of her clothing and accessories. The woman is depicted with a calm and serene expression, radiating a sense of elegance and grace. Gérôme's meticulous attention to detail is evident in the depiction of her jewellery, headdress, and the folds of her garments, showcasing his technical skill and precision.

The painting highlights Gérôme's interest in the Orientalist aesthetic, which sought to depict the customs, attire, and lifestyles of cultures deemed exotic by Western audiences. *Woman of Constantinople* reflects the Western fascination with the Ottoman Empire and its distinctive cultural heritage, emphasising the beauty and allure of its women. The same observation can be made about *Egyptian Girl* (Fig. 17), painted a year later: the young woman is depicted in traditional Egyptian attire, wearing a vibrant and ornate costume adorned with jewellery and accessories. Gérôme pays close attention to the intricate patterns and textures of her clothing, highlighting the rich cultural heritage of Egypt — but the gaze meeting the viewer is the painter's own gaze, not the sitter's. The girl's gaze is directed towards the viewer, engaging them with a mixture of innocence and curiosity. Her facial expression is calm and composed, hinting at a sense of inner strength and resilience. Gérôme captures a sense of enigma and allure in the girl's features, inviting the viewer to contemplate her story and the cultural context she represents — the cultural context, that is, that the painter has constructed for her.



Fig. 17 — Jean-Léon Gérôme, Egyptian Girl, oil on canvas, 46.7 × 38.1 cm, 1877.

The Italian artist Fabio Fabbi (1861–1910) was also influenced by the European fascination with the exotic and the Orient during the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries. Fabbi's painting portrays a scene within the harem, depicting concubines in various poses and engaged in activities. The composition showcases the women lounging, conversing, or engaged in leisurely pursuits. The setting is depicted as opulent and luxurious, with vibrant colours, rich textiles, and intricate details. Through his painting, Fabbi aimed to evoke a sense of intrigue, fantasy, and eroticism that appealed to Western audiences at the time. These depictions were often created based on Western fantasies and stereotypes of the Orient rather

than a true understanding of the diverse cultures and lived experiences of the people depicted.



Fig. 15 — Fabio Fabbri, Concubines in the Harem, oil on canvas, 35 × 45 cm, c. 1890. The painting's opulence is matched by its inaccuracy: Fabbri's "harem" is a fantasy compounded from secondary sources, theatrical sets, and the studio props of the European Orientalist trade.

Another interesting painting featuring women was done by Jāzeps Grosvalds (1891–1920), a Latvian artist who was interested in the “Oriental” world from his adolescence. His first real meeting with the imagined Oriental atmosphere took place in 1913, when he travelled to Spain and visited Toledo, Córdoba, Seville, and Granada. The trip impressed him with the versatility of colours, light, ambiance, and architectural forms, and was depicted in a sketchbook. Nevertheless, the real transformation of Grosvalds’s artistic expression occurred during his travels through Persia. Owing to the circumstances of the First World War, at the end of 1917, he joined the Mesopotamian Front under the English Command. The campaign took place in 1918, and he crossed Iran and Iraq.



Fig. 13 — Jāzepe Grosvalds, Three Women on the Street of Baghdad, watercolour on paper, 27.5 × 22.7 cm, 1918. “Only on the last day,” Grosvalds wrote, “I composed something nice — three rosy women in a narrow street of Baghdad.”

The army remained for three weeks in Baghdad, preparing for the campaign proper through Iran. While there, Grosvalds wrote: “I am not very satisfied — everything I draw seems very pale and non-original, comparing with what I have seen, but I hope to make something later. Only on the last day, I composed something nice — three rosy women in a narrow street of Baghdad.” Grosvalds also depicts interiors, showing the richness of carpets, different Persian traditions — water pipes, musical instruments, and, naturally, the dressing habits of men and women. He notices that in the rural areas and smaller villages women wear colourful

costumes and cover only the head, while nearer the city, all women are “carefully veiled in their black chadors, and with a black mask with a gold border on the face.”



Fig. 14 — Jāzeps Grosvalds, Women in a Street of Hamadan, watercolour on paper, 23 × 16 cm, 1918, Latvian National Museum of Art.

Grosvalds is interesting precisely because he is not French, English, or Italian; the Latvian Orientalist confirms that the genre had become a pan-European one by the early twentieth century, available even to peripheral national traditions. He was also unusually self-critical for an artist of his

moment — his diaries record both the rapture of the colour and his own embarrassment about the limits of his understanding — and his early death in 1920, at twenty-eight, makes the small body of his Mesopotamian work particularly poignant.

It is crucial to highlight that the depiction of women in courtly settings and portraits ranges across various artistic genres, historical eras, and cultural contexts. While some works of art might support established gender roles and standards, others might question or undermine them. Additionally, when interpreting these pieces of art, it is important to take into account the artist's viewpoint, the patron's preferences, and societal norms about women in formal situations. These portraits provide an overall view of affluent women's lifestyles and the values of courtly society. They demonstrate the artistic prowess and aesthetics of the period while offering insights into the roles, goals, and cultural ideals connected with noble and royal society.

CHAPTER FOUR

Women in Everyday Life



Domestic Interiors, Public Streets, and the Politics of the Bath

4.1 *The everyday as subject*

If religious painting put women on a vertical axis between God and earth, and courtly painting put them on a horizontal axis among other members of the elite, the painting of everyday life reaches for a third coordinate altogether: the diagonal of the ordinary, the slow, the cyclical. Women in Middle Eastern paintings of everyday life are seen participating in a variety of tasks and obligations within their communities. These pieces of art provide glimpses into the daily activities, obligations, and relationships of women from various socioeconomic strata and geographic locations. They are arguably the most underrated branch of the art-historical record — partly because their subject matter (cooking, cleaning, talking, walking) has often been read as “unimportant,” partly because the artists who painted them were sometimes minor figures in the larger national canons, and partly because the works themselves were dispersed in private hands rather than gathered into great museum holdings.

These paintings frequently feature women in domestic environments — homes, kitchens, gardens. They are often shown cooking, cleaning, looking after children, or taking care of household chores. These representations draw attention to the crucial function that women perform in upholding

and supporting their families and communities; the depiction of Eastern women in their quarters was also the most popular of all the themes in Orientalist painting, although in the European Orientalist tradition the domestic frequently shaded into the eroticised. Some of the most famous Oriental iconography — and the most influential in shaping Western aesthetics — depicts harems. Male artists who had no access to real seraglios relied on a kind of auditory fantasy — the second-hand reports of female travellers, the Arabic and Turkish manuals on architecture and household management, the engravings published with travel narratives — and on stage props of their own studios in Paris, London, and Rome. The result, in the work of artists like Ingres, Delacroix, Gérôme, Rosati, and Fabbi, is the famous “harem of European painting”: a fantasy compounded from selective evidence and projected desire.

4.2 Coffee, conversation, and the Ottoman interior

Social interactions are frequently depicted in Middle Eastern paintings of women in daily life. This might involve groups of women congregating in marketplaces, exchanging jokes and stories, or taking part in social gatherings and rituals. These pieces of art portray the sisterhood, community, and friendship ties that are essential to women’s lives. All genre paintings of Jean-Baptiste Vanmour, for example, depicted the daily life in Ottoman society, especially the harem — a term that, properly used, designates the area of the house occupied by women, where men outside the immediate family were not admitted.

The carefully studied subjects of Vanmour’s paintings and the accuracy of his representations suggest that they were undoubtedly based on

personal observations of traditions. Another possible source of information might have been Lady Mary Wortley Montagu, the wife of the British ambassador. Being one of Vanmour's clients, she could have told him details of Ottoman harem life. It is known that Lady Mary, along with her close friend Madeleine Françoise d'Usson de Bonnac, the wife of the French ambassador, visited a few harems and described them in her diary. Her famous letter from the women's baths at Sofia in 1717 — describing the women as moving “with the same majestic Grace, which Milton describes our General Mother with” — was, when it appeared in 1763, one of the first European accounts of Ottoman women's social life by an actual observer of it. It also became, ironically, one of the founding documents of the European harem fantasy: as Reina Lewis has shown in her invaluable *Rethinking Orientalism* (2004), Lady Mary's sober prose was rapidly conscripted into an erotic literary tradition over which she had no further control.



Fig. 21 — Jean-Baptiste Vanmour, Women Drinking Coffee, oil on canvas, 37 × 59 cm, first half of the eighteenth century, Suna and İnan Kıraç Foundation, Istanbul. The painting's precision in costume and ceremony reflects Vanmour's nearly four decades as a resident artist in Constantinople.

Vanmour was born in Valenciennes in 1671 and spent the last 38 years of his life in Constantinople, where he died in 1737. His extensive output — more than 300 paintings of Ottoman costume types, court ceremonies, and interior scenes — became one of the principal European sources of visual information about the Ottoman world. Crucially, he painted what he saw, and he saw a great deal. *Women Drinking Coffee* depicts a small social scene with a precision of detail that no second-hand European Orientalist painting of the same period can match: the long-handled coffee pot, the small cups, the cushions, the embroidered silks, the woman lighting a small water pipe, the woman pouring. This is not a fantasy. It is a documentary.

In Osman Hamdi Bey's painting *Ottoman Lady Preparing for an Outing* we see an elegantly dressed Ottoman young woman in the harem filled with traditional Ottoman furnishings. She is seen regarding her reflection in the mirror while dressing, and appears to be from a privileged background; she wears a yellow-ochre dress. As a member of an upper Ottoman family, Osman Hamdi Bey lived a very Western life. In 1860, his family sent him to Paris to continue his education. There he decided to pursue his passion for painting and studied art under the supervision of renowned French Orientalist painters Jean-Léon Gérôme and Gustave Boulanger. He returned to Istanbul in 1869 and went on to become the founding director of the Imperial Museum (later the Istanbul Archaeological Museum) in 1881 and the founding director of the Ottoman Empire's first fine arts academy, the Sanayi-i Nefise Mekteb-i Âlisi, in 1882.

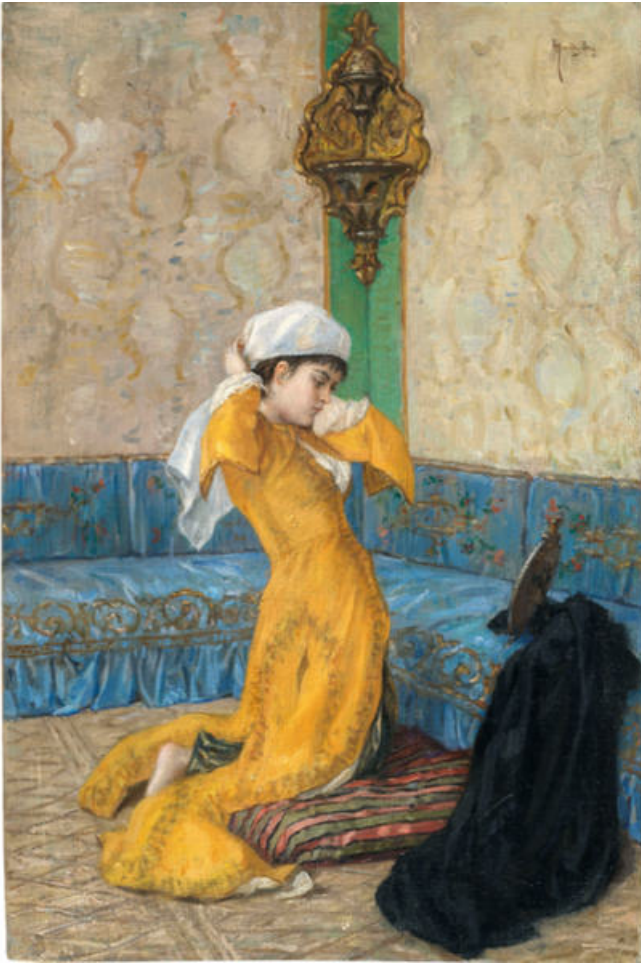


Fig. 22 — Osman Hamdi Bey, Ottoman Lady Preparing for an Outing, oil on canvas on panel, 68 × 45 cm. Hamdi Bey's tiles, his calligraphy, his Qur'an stand and his folding writing-desk are taken from his own collection: the painting is, among other things, a portrait of a curator's eye.

In another of his paintings, *Women on the Walk*, Hamdi Bey portrays a group of women walking together engaged in conversation and leisurely strolling. We see a diverse group of women dressed in vibrant and intricately designed Ottoman clothing, depicted in motion, with graceful postures and gestures, suggesting a sense of camaraderie and enjoyment of each other's company. The composition creates a dynamic and lively

atmosphere, capturing the essence of a social outing or gathering. *Women on the Walk* reflects the artist's interest in depicting scenes from everyday life and celebrating the social interactions and relationships among women. It highlights the importance of community, friendship, and the shared experiences of women within Ottoman society. The painting also serves as a window into the cultural and social norms of the time, revealing insights into the roles and activities of women in Ottoman society. It presents a positive and empowering portrayal of women, emphasising their agency, companionship, and the joy of simply being together.



Fig. 23 — Osman Hamdi Bey, Women on the Walk, late nineteenth century. Hamdi Bey's women are not posing for the painter; they are walking, talking, attending to one another.

Women in everyday-life paintings reflect the cultural practices, customs, and traditions prevalent in the region. They showcase the diverse roles and identities of women, including their contributions as mothers, wives, daughters, friends, and community members. These artworks shed light on the values, relationships, and dynamics within Middle Eastern societies. Hamdi Bey is in this respect a counter-Gérôme: he was trained inside the same academic apparatus, he uses some of the same techniques, but his

women are not the property of the painter's viewer. They are, by some quiet but legible margin, in possession of themselves.

4.3 *The bath, the mirror, and the racial gaze*

In Jean-Léon Gérôme's paintings — to return to a more troubled tradition — it is important to engage critically with works such as *The Bath*. Orientalist art often perpetuated stereotypes and exoticised the subjects, reflecting Western fantasies of the East. The portrayal of Middle Eastern women in the bath can be seen through the lens of the male gaze and the Western fascination with the eroticism and exoticism of the "other." In this painting, Gérôme depicts a Black woman giving a bath to a Caucasian woman, and we can clearly see Arabic writing on the upper right side. In this case, we can understand the symbolism of this painting's setting in the Arab world.

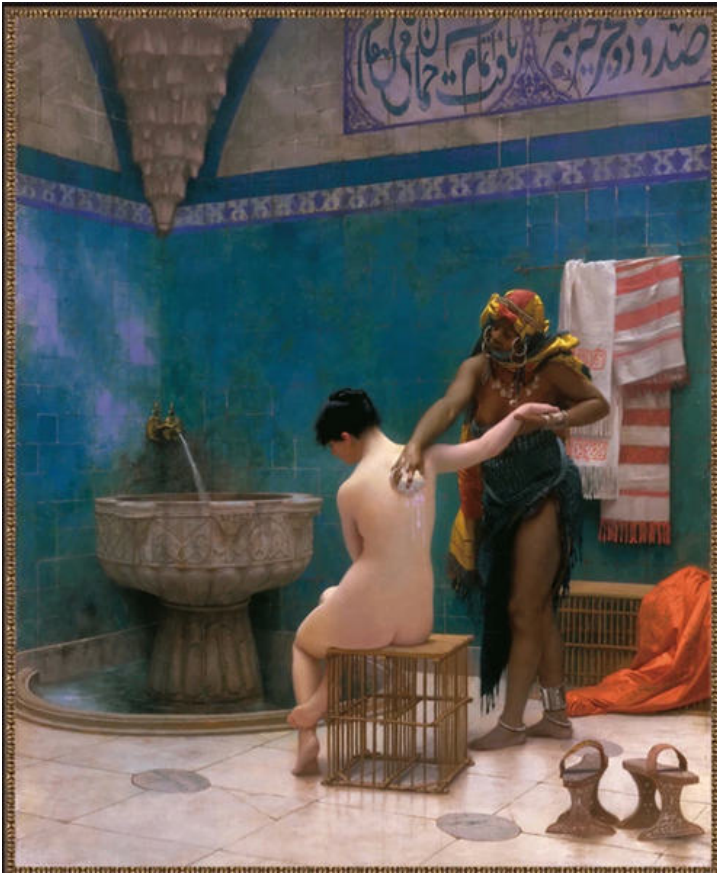


Fig. 24 — Jean-Léon Gérôme, The Bath, 1880–1885. The painting’s racial composition — a Black servant attending a white-skinned bather — is a frank illustration of the European Orientalist imagination, which regularly used the visual juxtaposition of racialised bodies to construct its fantasy of the East.

Another important point here is the relationship between the two women. Gérôme depicts the white woman’s face as turned away from the African woman, encouraging the viewer to read a racial as well as a class distance into the scene. The painting belongs to a long European visual tradition — one runs back to Titian’s *Venus and Cupid with an Organist* (c. 1550), forwards to Manet’s *Olympia* (1863) — in which a white female nude is attended by a Black servant, and the racial pairing functions both as a marker of the bather’s class and as a coded comment on the moral status

of the scene. In Gérôme's *Bath* the convention is transposed onto an explicitly Middle Eastern setting, and the Arabic calligraphy in the upper right confirms that the eroticism is to be read as "oriental" — that is, as both desirable and safely distant from the European viewer.

This iconography offers a counterbalance to the often idealised and elevated representations seen in religious or courtly art. They provide a more intimate and relatable portrayal of women's experiences, emphasising their resilience, strength, and the importance of their labour in sustaining households and communities — but only on the condition that we read them critically. The *Bath* shows female labour. It also subordinates that labour to the comfort of a bather whom the painting itself codes as the only "person" in the room. Read against the grain, the painting tells us at least as much about the European discomfort with imagining household servants as full historical subjects as it does about Egyptian or Levantine bath culture, which had its own elaborate social architecture and which was, at the time Gérôme was painting, undergoing rapid transformation.

It is important to note that the portrayal of women in everyday-life paintings may also be influenced by societal expectations and cultural norms of the time and place in which the artworks were created. Artists may present women within traditional gender roles, while others may challenge or subvert these roles by highlighting their agency, creativity, or individuality. Women in everyday-life paintings in the Middle East offer a window into the diverse experiences, roles, and relationships of women within their respective communities. They capture the beauty, vitality, and everyday struggles of women, showcasing their contributions and resilience in shaping and enriching Middle Eastern societies.

4.4 The streets of Baghdad, Hamadan, Cairo

The street scene was, for the European Orientalists, a relatively rare subject — partly because painting on location in the public streets of an Ottoman or Iranian city was not a particularly comfortable enterprise — but for the Middle Eastern artists who came of age in the first half of the twentieth century, the public spaces of Cairo, Baghdad, Tehran, Beirut, Istanbul, and Damascus became central to a national modern art. They had a political reason to claim those streets as artistic subjects: the public sphere was where the new mass politics of the post-Ottoman era was being made, and the painter who could put a peasant or a vendor or a woman walking in the street at the centre of his canvas was making, by that gesture, a claim about who belonged to the public.

The Egyptian painter Mahmoud Mukhtar (1891–1934) — better known as a sculptor — produced both painted and sculpted versions of the rural Egyptian woman, the fellaha, in the 1920s and 1930s. Mukhtar's *Nahdat Misr* (Egypt's Awakening, 1928), the great granite sculpture installed near Cairo's railway station, depicts a fellaha rising from the haunches of a sphinx, her arm reaching across her body to lift the veil from her face. The image became one of the icons of Egyptian nationalism. The Iraqi painter Shakir Hassan al-Said (1925–2004) painted the women of Baghdad's old quarters with a tenderness that grew sharper after his conversion to Sufism in the 1960s. The Lebanese painter Saliba Douaihy (1912–1994) produced a series of village scenes that placed Maronite women at the centre of an iconography of land, family, and continuity. The Syrian painter Louay Kayyali (1934–1978) — to whom we will return — painted the working women of Aleppo and Damascus in the 1960s and 1970s, often the cigarette vendor, the lottery-ticket seller, the homeless mother with her sleeping child, in a deliberately hieratic style that confers on them the dignity of icons.

4.5 The unseen labour: Middle Eastern women painting Middle Eastern women

The historiographical irony of the everyday-life genre is that the women best placed to paint it — the female members of Middle Eastern households — were, until well into the twentieth century, the least likely to have access to the academies, ateliers, and exhibition spaces that would have allowed them to do so. Mihri Müşfik Hanım, discussed in the previous chapter, was one of a tiny number of women who broke through. The Egyptian painter Effat Naghi (1905–1994), the Iraqi painter Madiha Umar (1908–2005), the Syrian painter Leila Nseir (b. 1941), the Iranian painter Iran Darroudi (1936–2021), the Palestinian painter Sophie Halaby (1906–1998), and the Lebanese painter Saloua Raouda Choucair (1916–2017) belong to the second generation of women who acquired sustained painting careers in the first half of the twentieth century. Their bodies of work — taken together — constitute the regional archive that everyday-life painting needs in order to be balanced.

Choucair, in particular, deserves a separate mention. Trained in Beirut and then in Paris in the late 1940s, she developed a distinctive abstract vocabulary that drew on both modular Islamic geometry and post-war European modernism. She painted, sculpted, and engineered. Her subjects were not always identifiably women — much of her work is non-figurative — but the subject of her career, in the long run, was the question of how a woman could occupy the position of artist within a regional tradition that had given her surprisingly few models. Her 2013 retrospective at Tate Modern, three years before her death, settled her place in the global modernist canon. The story of Middle Eastern women painting Middle Eastern women is, in many ways, the story of how Choucair, Halaby, Naghi, Umar, Nseir, and their contemporaries broke open the institutional space within which the next generation could work.

CHAPTER FIVE

Women in Islamic Painting and the Symbolism of the Veil



Aniconism, Calligraphy, and the Politics of Modesty

5.1 Introduction: aniconism and its discontents

Islamic art depicts women in a complex and varied way that crosses geographical boundaries and historical eras. It spans a variety of media, including calligraphy, architecture, painting, textiles, and pottery, all of which contain female figures in them. Islamic art has a long history of avoiding the overt depiction of women — and other human beings — in religious settings. This custom has its roots in the idea of aniconism, which forbids the representation of living things to reduce the possibility of idolatry or the worship of objects. As a result, Islamic religious art frequently concentrates on geometric patterns, floral motifs, and calligraphy. However, women have been shown in Islamic art in a wide variety of ways in non-religious situations.

The story is more complicated than the standard textbook account allows. The hadith literature contains a number of warnings against the visual

representation of living creatures, but it also contains hadiths whose authenticity is contested and whose interpretation has varied dramatically across the schools of Islamic jurisprudence. In practice, the absence of figural representation in classical Islamic religious architecture (the mosque, the madrasa, the mausoleum) was paired with a flourishing tradition of figural painting in non-religious contexts: court manuscripts, illustrated histories, frontispieces, secular wall painting, and ceramic decoration. The notion that Islamic art is by nature uninterested in the human figure is itself a Western art-historical construction, formulated in the late nineteenth century at exactly the moment when the European art market was learning to value the geometrical and calligraphic strands of Islamic visual culture and to dismiss the figural ones as anomalies.

The representation of women in courtly scenes — whether they are noblewomen, princesses, or members of affluent families — is a recurrent motif. These paintings frequently emphasise the elegance, beauty, and refinement associated with courtly culture by showing women in opulent settings partaking in leisurely activities like music or dance. Islamic art has also portrayed women on textiles and pottery. Many Islamic civilisations have a long history of textile manufacture, and these fabrics frequently incorporate intricate designs featuring images of women, either as stylised individuals or in narrative situations. Images of women may also be seen on ceramics — tiles or pottery — frequently incorporated into larger decorative patterns or architectural components. The Iznik tiles of Ottoman Anatolia, the Kashan lustreware of medieval Iran, the carved stucco of Fatimid Egypt all carry female figural elements that the standard surveys have under-discussed.

In Islamic art, women are frequently portrayed as modest and polite, adhering to the social and religious norms of the time. This is frequently demonstrated by the wearing of veils, baggy clothing, and reserved

postures. Islamic art has portrayed women in a variety of ways throughout different geographical regions and historical eras, reflecting the various cultural, social, and aesthetic influences found throughout the Islamic world. The portrayal of women has received more attention in modern Islamic art. Women artists from the Islamic world have engaged in discussions about feminism, identity, and social issues through their work, challenging stereotypes and subverting established gender norms. These artists have aimed to express their own voices and experiences as well as reclaim the narrative surrounding women's representation.



Fig. 25 — John Frederick Lewis, A Veiled Egyptian Girl, watercolour and bodycolour, 39 × 28 cm, mid-nineteenth century. Lewis lived in Cairo from 1841 to 1851 and his Cairene watercolours are among the most ethnographically attentive Orientalist paintings of the period.

It is significant to note that there are numerous diverse aesthetic expressions and interpretations of women in Islamic art across various historical periods, geographical places, and individual artists. Islamic artists' artistic objectives and worldviews — as well as cultural, historical, and religious influences — all have an impact on how women are portrayed in their works. The early Islamic period itself was an age of vigorous figural decoration: the Umayyad bath complex at Qusayr 'Amra (built between 723 and 743 CE in present-day Jordan) is decorated with frescoes that include female bathers, musicians, and personifications of the seasons. The Abbasid palace of Samarra (ninth century, in present-day Iraq) contained wall paintings of dancing women. The Fatimid wood ceilings of the Cappella Palatina in Palermo (twelfth century, painted by Muslim artists for a Norman Christian king) include female musicians. None of these images are religious; all of them are Islamic.

5.2 The symbolism of the veil

In Middle Eastern paintings, the veil and other modesty symbols have deep cultural, religious, and societal meanings. The veil has been explored and depicted artistically throughout history, reflecting the rich and varied connotations attached to it. The veil is frequently seen as a representation of modesty, chastity, and virtue in Middle Eastern cultures. It stands for a woman's dedication to preserving her privacy and maintaining her self-respect. By covering her hair, neck, and even her face, a lady expresses her wish to protect her beauty and preserve her sense of privacy. However, images of veiled women in paintings are often interpreted to exemplify the stereotypes of Muslim women as oppressed, passive, silent,

powerless, and backward. These stereotypes and views are themselves an act of Orientalism.

The lens through which the West views the veil today can be traced back to nineteenth-century Orientalism. Within Orientalist representations, the veil conjures both eroticism and oppression. When the Arab East was first colonised, it was seen as mysterious and alluring, and this was translated by the image of the mysterious yet alluring veiled woman, as is clear in Edward Said's analysis of how the West consistently produced an image of the East as its inverse: where the West was enlightened, the Orient was barbaric; where the West was free, the Orient was despotic; where the West was rational, the Orient was sensual. The veiled woman was the visual condensation of all three of these inversions, which is one reason why so much European Orientalist painting returned to it obsessively. The veil was the painter's alibi: it allowed him to construct the fantasy of seduction without committing to it; it gave him plausible deniability about whose face, exactly, he was painting.

A little Arab girl wearing a veil is depicted in Étienne Dinet's painting *Young Girl with a Veil* (Fig. 26) in a way that is both innocent and beautiful. The French Orientalist painter Étienne Dinet (1861–1929) was well known for his portrayals of Algeria and other countries in North Africa. Dinet differs from other European Orientalists in one significant respect: he learned Arabic, lived in the Saharan town of Bou Saada from the late 1880s onwards, converted to Islam in 1913, and adopted the name Nasreddine. After his death in Paris in 1929, his body was returned to Bou Saada and buried at his own request in a small mausoleum. His Orientalism is therefore more than a project of fantasy — it is also, more rarely for a French painter of his period, an act of identification.



Fig. 26 — Étienne Dinet, Young Girl with a Veil, late nineteenth century. Dinet, unusually for a French Orientalist of his generation, learned Arabic, settled in the Algerian Sahara, and converted to Islam.

In this artwork, a little girl is depicted wearing a thin veil that partially obscures her face — a custom prevalent in several parts of the Middle East and North Africa. The exquisite decoration of the veil in vivid hues and patterns reflects the girl's community's cultural significance for veiling. It stands for modesty, privacy, and a person's sense of religious or cultural identity. The girl has a calm, thoughtful expression that conveys a feeling of quiet reflection. Her eyes show a depth of emotion and curiosity despite

being largely covered. The realism of the painting is enhanced by the artist's deft portrayal of the softness of her features and the subtle interplay of light and shadow. This symbolism goes beyond personal preference and connects to a larger sense of cultural identity. It reflects the rich tapestry of Middle Eastern traditions and rituals, and acts as a visual sign of a woman's allegiance with a particular community or religious organisation. The veil serves as a physical representation of cultural heritage, tying women to their ancestry and indicating their adherence to accepted social mores.

It also represents a sense of respect and safety. It protects women from unwelcome attention, objectification, and potential danger by acting as a shield. By donning the veil, a woman signals that her body and presence merit respect and consideration. She also sets boundaries and demands the acceptance of her autonomy. None of this is to deny that the veil has, in some times and places, been imposed coercively on women who would not have chosen it for themselves; that has happened — and it is happening, in some societies, today. But the visual archive of Middle Eastern painting cannot be reduced to that single political fact, any more than the visual archive of European painting can be reduced to the long history of state-imposed Christian dress codes for European women.

[Image not available: Fig. 27 — Mariano Fortuny, A Moroccan Woman in Traditional Dress, watercolour on paper, 1866. Fortuny's Moroccan women, painted on his trips of 1860 and 1862, are among the more ethnographically scrupulous works of the European Orientalist tradition.]

Mariano Fortuny's painting *A Moroccan Woman in Traditional Dress* is a mesmerising depiction of a Moroccan woman wearing traditional clothing. The exoticism and attraction of Middle Eastern and North African cultures were depicted in the Orientalist paintings of the Spanish painter, who travelled twice to Morocco — in 1860 (with the Catalan volunteers fighting

in the Spanish-Moroccan War) and in 1862 — and who collected a vast wardrobe of North African and Andalusian costumes that he used in subsequent paintings. In this painting, a Moroccan woman is shown wearing colourful, richly patterned, and highly detailed traditional clothing. The elaborate embroidery, luxurious fabrics, and decorative components are all captured in the artist's meticulous attention to detail. The vivid hues express the depth and variety of Moroccan culture.

The veil can have a variety of symbolic meanings in religious settings. For instance, the veil is frequently connected with modesty and humility in Islam, indicating a woman's devotion to her religion and her desire to carry out her religious duties. However, because religious customs and cultural interpretations vary across the Middle East, there may be some variation in how individuals and communities perceive the significance of the veil. On the other hand, it is depicted using a variety of artistic methods and approaches. The delicate materials, the play of light and shadow, and the intricacies of facial expression are typically captured in the complex details of the veils by artists. The veil takes on symbolic connotations and evokes feelings connected to social, religious, and cultural contexts through various creative representations. This illustrates the variety of women's experiences in the area. It includes ideas like respect, humility, cultural identity, safety, and religious piety. Middle Eastern artists advance knowledge of the various roles, customs, and aspirations of women in their respective countries by examining and expressing these symbolic features.

5.3 Women's roles in Islamic society as depicted in art

Women's responsibilities in Islamic culture have been portrayed in a variety of artistic mediums throughout the history of Islamic art, offering detailed insights into their social, cultural, and religious situations. Islamic

art — which includes a variety of media including calligraphy, miniature painting, ceramics, textiles, and architecture — has been an effective way to communicate and record the experiences of women in Islamic communities. Islamic art frequently depicts women in domestic and familial contexts, performing tasks like caring for children, attending to housework, or taking part in rituals. These representations emphasise the important roles that women play within the family unit and the contributions that they make to the welfare of their homes. Such depictions demonstrate the importance of fostering, providing for others, and preserving harmony in Islamic society.

In addition, Islamic art challenges the idea that women's participation in society is limited to the home domain by showing them in a variety of public roles. Women are portrayed as researchers, creators, businesswomen, and attendees of social and religious meetings. These representations emphasise women's agency and active participation in public life, breaking stereotypes and recognising their many contributions to their communities. The reading of the veil as a symbol of oppression originated in texts that portrayed Islamic culture as inferior and backward. Between 1800 and 1950, the West published an estimated sixty thousand books on the Arab East. The purpose of many of these books was to show the colonised Muslims that they were underdeveloped and in desperate need of "help" from the West. These texts depict Muslim women imprisoned by Berber Arab men, trapped in polygamous marriages, or forced to cover their bodies with veils. Wearing the hijab has, by contrast, become for many Muslim women a way to come out, and an easy means to identify who they are and what they represent. There have been efforts to reach out to the public with open dialogue, to initiate interfaith cooperation, and to work as productive societies.

Islamic art frequently depicts women in regard to their devotional and spiritual practices in relation to religious topics. Women are shown performing acts of prayer, reading and reciting passages from the Qur'an, and taking part in religious rituals. These portrayals emphasise the crucial part that women play in upholding religious customs and the value of their spiritual lives in Islamic civilisations. The Persian miniature painters of the Safavid period frequently included women in scenes of religious instruction; the Ottoman albums of the seventeenth century include images of female mystics; the courtly portraits of the Mughal period include the female poet, the female calligrapher, the female musician. The standard surveys of Islamic art have, until recently, treated these as exceptional cases. They are, on the contrary, surprisingly common — and the gap between the iconographic record and the standard narrative is now being closed by a generation of scholars including Sussan Babaie, Nada Shabout, and Yael Rice.

Moreover, the representation of women in Islamic art differs across various geographical locations, historical eras, and aesthetic movements. Cultural, social, and political issues can have an impact on how women are portrayed, which may in turn reflect the various views and practices that exist within Islamic societies. Islamic art's depictions of women offer a complex and nuanced picture of the responsibilities that women play in Islamic civilisation. In doing so, it challenges preconceptions and affirms their agency and worth, while highlighting their contributions to the private, public, and religious worlds. Islamic art illustrates the vast and varied experiences of women in Islamic countries, highlighting their tenacity, creativity, and crucial role in the development of Islamic culture.

5.4 Calligraphy as a site of feminine presence

One of the surprising places to look for women in Islamic visual culture is the calligraphic tradition. Female calligraphers have been documented in the Islamic world for at least a thousand years. The eleventh-century scholar al-Khatib al-Baghdadi mentions female copyists working in Baghdad's book markets; the twelfth-century encyclopaedist al-Nadim records a list of women trained in the proportional Arabic scripts; the Ottoman court ateliers employed female calligraphers from the late sixteenth century onwards, and the great twentieth-century Iraqi calligrapher Hashim Muhammad al-Baghdadi (1917–1973) trained a number of women, including his own daughter, in the classical hands.

Contemporary calligraphic painting — sometimes called “hurufiyya” after the Arabic word for letters, hurufiyya being the practice of using Arabic letters as primary visual elements rather than as the carrier of legible text — has been one of the most fertile sites for women artists from the Arab world since the 1960s. The Iraqi-British painter Madiha Umar (1908–2005) is now generally credited as the founder of hurufiyya; she was followed by, among many others, Wijdan Ali (Jordan), Inji Efflatoun (Egypt), and the contemporary master Naja al-Mahdaoui (Tunisia). The genre dissolves the question of female figural representation altogether: it is a way of being present in Islamic visual culture without ever painting a face. The line that runs from Umar's 1949 calligraphic compositions to the work of contemporary artists like Etel Adnan, Lala Rukh, and Lalla Essaydi is one of the great unstudied lineages of twentieth-century Middle Eastern art.

CHAPTER SIX

Contemporary Representations



From Tahia Halim to Shirin Neshat

6.1 Reclaiming the narrative

The unique and changing realities of women in the Middle East are reflected in current depictions of women in art. Artists engage with social, political, and cultural themes as well as stereotypes and conventional gender roles. We can explain how women are currently portrayed in Middle Eastern art by taking back narratives. Many contemporary Middle Eastern artists work to correct historical and cultural misrepresentations of women in order to reclaim the stories about them. It is their intention to present women as complicated beings with agency, resilience, and a variety of identities. These depictions go against the exoticised and essentialised perceptions of Middle Eastern women that are frequently found in Western media. They also intervene, increasingly, in the regional media — there is no “inside” of the Middle East that is innocent of gendered visual cliché — and the artists who do this work are often pulled in two directions at once: contesting the Orientalist frame for international audiences, and contesting the patriarchal frame for domestic ones.

Some statistics will help to fix the contemporary moment. As of the 2024 Sharjah Biennial, women constituted approximately 56 per cent of participating artists from the wider Middle East and North Africa region —

the first major regional biennial at which female participants outnumbered male ones. The Sotheby's Middle Eastern auction season of 2024 saw the work of women artists account for 23 per cent of total lots and 34 per cent of total sales by value, the highest figures recorded since records began in 2007. The most expensive work by a Middle Eastern woman artist sold at auction is, as of this writing, a painting by the Lebanese artist Etel Adnan, which sold at Christie's London in 2023 for £1.3 million. None of these numbers represent parity. All of them represent a transformation that the previous generation of regional artists could scarcely have imagined.

When artists are trying to represent empowerment and resistance, women are frequently shown in contemporary Middle Eastern art as agents of change who express their authority and defy social standards. Themes of empowerment, resilience, and resistance against patriarchal norms are explored. This type of art honours the resilience, activism, and bravery of women in the face of societal and political obstacles. On the other hand, identity and intersectionality are an important track: regional artists approach concerns including race, class, religion, and sexuality while examining the intersecting realities of women. They work with the complications of multiple identities and reject the stereotypical perceptions of Middle Eastern women. Women's life experiences are diverse and complex, and this is reflected in the artwork.

Another track is the self-expression and body track. Many artists examine how to represent the female body while questioning social conventions of modesty and beauty. They push limits and inquire about society's taboos as they explore issues of sexuality, body positivity, and self-expression. These portrayals seek to free women from constricting ideas of femininity. Arab artists adapted to European traditions, leading them to execute portraits of society ladies, nymphs, landscapes, and still lives in the

classical method of the Renaissance and Orientalism — but these were eventually appropriated and re-tooled. The portrayal of Western political ideologies, the French Revolution and Napoleon’s Egyptian expedition, as well as the literary, philosophical, and artistic European movements of the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, became part of the regional artistic vocabulary. Contemporary Middle Eastern artists utilise their work to comment on social and political issues that affect the lives of women. They address issues such as social injustice, political oppression, conflict, displacement, and gender inequality. They contribute to larger discussions about social change and give voice to women’s experiences through their art. The global and transnational perspectives of Middle Eastern artists place them in transnational discourses, linking their personal stories to larger feminist movements and international discussions of gender and identity. By establishing relationships and promoting intercultural dialogues, they challenge stereotypes and alter views of women in the Middle East.

6.2 Women artists and their use of the female body

The female body has long been a potent and complex subject for female artists to explore in their work. They have questioned ideas of beauty, questioned societal conventions, and reclaimed their own stories through their investigation of the feminine body. Women artists have positioned themselves as both makers and subjects of their art by using their own bodies as a canvas — and we could clearly see this in Frida Kahlo’s artworks when she said, “I paint self-portraits because I am so often alone, because I am the person I know best.” Kahlo is, of course, Mexican rather than Middle Eastern, but the dictum applies. The Middle Eastern women painters of the second half of the twentieth century often took themselves as subject when no one else was prepared to.

The Turkish actress and painter Zerrin Tekindor (b. 1964) revolves around drawing portraits of women in addition to her personal pictures. In one of her interviews with *Raillife* magazine — a Turkish publication produced for the passengers of High-Speed Train (YHT) by the TSDD Foundation — she said, when asked what inspires her to draw, “the art of theatre is the greatest source of inspiration; painting and acting exist in my life together and I cannot think of them separately.” Tekindor, best known to Turkish audiences as a screen and stage actress, has produced a body of small-format portraits — most of them of women, many of them of friends — that has won her a quiet but substantial collector base since the early 2010s.



Fig. 28 — Zerrin Tekindor, Portrait of Anna X, mixed media on board, 20 × 20 cm, 2021.

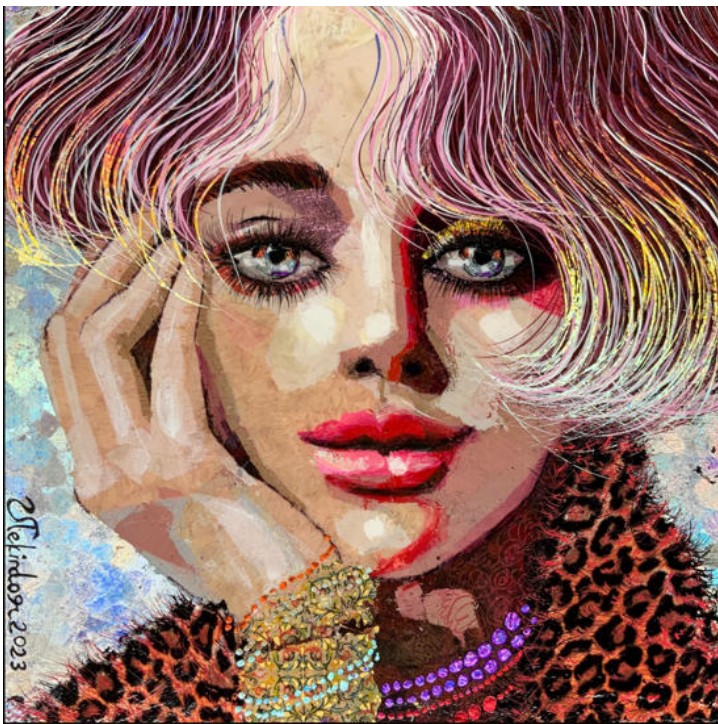


Fig. 29 — Zerrin Tekindor, Portrait of Rohais Moreau, mixed media on board, 30 × 30 cm, 2023.

Women artists' use of the female body as a subject is a form of empowerment and resistance: a defiance of the male gaze and the presentation of a different viewpoint on the experience of women. Female bodies have been portrayed by women artists in a variety of ways, from realistic renderings to abstract and symbolic interpretations. The artist Tahia Halim — born in 1919 in the city of Dongola, Sudan — drew inspiration from the region of Nubia located between Aswan in southern Egypt and Khartoum in central Sudan. Though she was technically born in the region, she had spent most of her life in Cairo, and she was not ethnically Nubian. The area remained somewhat mysterious to her until a highly influential trip in the late 1950s, when she started to paint the character of Nubian women and the identity of the region.



Fig. 30 — Tahia Halim, Three Nubians, oil on panel, 1970. Halim painted the Nubians in the years that the High Aswan Dam was inundating their villages — an iconography of cultural memory in the moment of its erasure.

One painting from this period — *Three Nubians* — depicts three girls occupying the middle of the composition, implied to be sitting by a source of water. The colours of the characters' clothes and their dark complexions contrast with the background, painted in muted whites, to the extent that they appear to be floating. The central woman holds a plant in her hands, signifying the fertility and abundance of rural life along the Nile, which bisects the length of the region. Here, Halim's passion for Egypt's cultural heritage is as evident as her aesthetic interest in Nubia, showing influences from a diverse selection of Egyptian sources. Before the construction of Aswan High Dam between 1960 and 1970, she travelled to this region. She

discovered the richness of its environment, climate, and people, whose simple way of life seemed to embody centuries-old traditions. This trip marked the beginning of a new stage in her oeuvre, characterised by a mystical, somewhat primitivist fascination with symbolism. As an Arab Egyptian of relatively high social standing, Halim observed Nubia through a lens of privilege that positioned her as the “evolved” or “civilised” urbanite and the Nubians as “primitive” — a complication that the painter herself, by all accounts, gradually came to recognise.

The historical irony is that Halim’s great series on Nubia was painted in exactly the years that the High Dam was inundating Nubian villages and forcibly relocating their inhabitants. Halim was painting an iconography of cultural memory at the moment of its physical erasure. The dignity of her three young women, holding a plant in the centre of the composition, becomes — read against this background — an act of mourning. Her work alongside that of her near contemporary Inji Efflatoun (1924–1989), who was imprisoned for her communist activism between 1959 and 1963 and who painted the women in Egyptian prisons, helps to reset the conventional history of mid-century Egyptian art away from its accustomed centre on male figures.

Women artists have pushed the boundaries of conventional beauty standards and praised the individuality of women’s bodies by expressing the subtleties and diversity of the female form. Additionally, women artists have reclaimed their agency by challenging patriarchal narratives through their portrayals of the female body. They have challenged societal norms and prejudices, upending established power structures that have historically objectified and manipulated women’s bodies. By doing this, they have defended their freedom to self-expression and contested the tradition of women’s historically repressed exclusion from artistic discourse.

Two further contemporary artists deserve mention here. Lalla Essaydi (b. 1956), a Moroccan-born photographer and painter who lives between Marrakech, Boston, and New York, has made the most ambitious recent body of work directly engaging the European Orientalist archive. Her series *Les Femmes du Maroc* (2005–2008) restages compositions by Delacroix, Ingres, and other nineteenth-century French Orientalists with Moroccan women whose entire bodies, costumes, and settings are covered in flowing Arabic calligraphy in henna. The text is taken from her own journals; it is, by Islamic legal tradition, a script that women are permitted to write but which historically they have rarely been formally trained to inscribe in this monumental way. The work is at once a critique of the male European Orientalist tradition (the iconography is borrowed but the subject of the inscription is the woman's own private writing) and a critique of male Islamic tradition (the calligraphy is a script women have not been assigned). It is one of the most important contemporary feminist artistic projects of the past two decades.

Huguette Caland (1931–2019), the daughter of Lebanon's first post-independence president, Bechara El Khoury, is the second. Caland began painting in the 1960s and produced through the 1970s and 1980s a body of mostly small-scale, almost-abstract works whose subject was, again and again, the female body — usually her own — rendered in soft, almost pneumatic shapes that hover between landscape and figure. Her great series of self-portraits is shockingly frank without ever being literal. The 2024 retrospective at the Drawing Center in New York and the Tate St Ives have together established Caland as one of the central figures of late-twentieth-century Lebanese art, and her work is a useful reminder that the “Middle Eastern woman's body” has been a subject of regional women painters for far longer than the international art market has been ready to recognise.

6.3 Art and political activism

The portrayal of women at the crossroads of art and political activism is a dynamic and diverse phenomenon that demonstrates the ability of artistic expression to subvert social and political norms, promote women's rights, and effect social change. Artists have long challenged gender injustices, brought attention to women's issues, and amplified the voices of oppressed women through their artistic mediums. Political activism has historically used art as a potent tool, enabling artists to communicate important ideas and raise social awareness. Artists have employed their art to question and undermine prevalent myths and stereotypes that support gender inequality and oppression in the context of how women are portrayed. They have challenged established gender stereotypes and redefined cultural expectations by presenting women as strong, resilient, and empowered individuals.

The Palestinian artist Nabil Anani depicts women in his paintings as major figures within the landscape, representing an allegory of Palestine. He depicts women as the mother — the source of nourishment and shelter for her people. In an interview with Anani in his Ramallah studio in August 2023, he described the presence of a female figure as a foremost visual signifier of national identity. He considers the mother as the motherland. He invests the image of Palestine with maternal symbolism: a landscape in full bloom, stone houses, and women wearing traditional costumes, surrounded by children, or engaged in domestic activities such as baking bread, grinding wheat, and harvesting crops, fruits, and olives. Anani was born in 1943, during a critical stage in Palestinian history; his childhood was shaped by the Nakba, which saw the destruction of many cities,

towns, and villages — and he has lived almost his entire life in the West Bank, including the long years of the Israeli occupation that began in 1967.



Fig. 31 — Nabil Anani, Motherhood, oil on canvas, 75 × 85 cm, 1995. Anani uses the maternal figure as a visual signifier of Palestinian national identity, drawing the embroidery of the woman's dress from the traditional tatreez of the West Bank villages.

In *Motherhood*, the landscape is reduced to an arch of vines, and the peasant woman's embroidered dress has lost its regional specificity and has been replaced with the four colours of the Palestinian flag. In *Mother's Embrace*, the Palestinian woman shines bright in her national Palestinian dress embroidered with distinctive motifs. Anani depicts a woman in a white scarf and a dress studded with people and an olive branch, standing with a gesture and a bow of the head, embracing Al-Aqsa Mosque and the

old historic houses. The iconography is unambiguous; the politics, in this corner of the world, is unavoidable. The dress itself — the tatreez of the West Bank villages — has, since 2021, been inscribed on the UNESCO Representative List of the Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity, an institutional recognition that has both ratified and politicised it.



Fig. 32 — Nabil Anani, Mother's Embrace, acrylic on canvas, 120 × 75 cm, 1995.

Politically active artists frequently aim to shed light on women's experiences, fight for their rights, and draw attention to important social issues like violence against women, reproductive rights, gender-based

discrimination, and barriers based on culture and religion. Through their thought-provoking and emotive artworks, they hope to foster empathy, spark debate, and motivate action. Art can also act as a spark for social movements and group initiatives. Images of women's challenges, victories, and resilience can strike a powerful chord with viewers, generating a sense of community and inspiring groups to push for change. These pieces of art encourage people to examine and oppose oppressive systems, challenge social norms, and foster discourse.

The Yemeni artist Saba Jallas's paintings often represent a call for peace and coexistence, as well as a rejection of war and its tragic consequences. She expresses the well-known problems that afflict society. As Jallas explains, "Maybe because I see women as a symbol of compassion." Through her artwork, Jallas finds an outlet to express her humanity and absolute optimism: "I find that the solution lies in loving each other. And that's why I was keen on showcasing, through my artworks, even a sliver of beauty in this war." Saba Muhammad Jallas is from Sanaa and a graduate of French literature; she worked on drawing as a hobby until the outbreak of war and started painting in oil colours in 2017, after she was unemployed because of the war. The Yemeni civil war, now in its second decade, is among the largest humanitarian catastrophes of the contemporary world, and the role of an artist like Jallas — painting domestic scenes in a country where the everyday has been so violently interrupted — is, by quiet implication, political.



Fig. 33 — Saba Jallas, Untitled, acrylic on canvas. Jallas began painting in 2017 after the war in Yemen left her unemployed; her work is, in her own description, “a sliver of beauty in this war.”

The representation of women at the nexus of art and political activism is not limited to any one medium or aesthetic. It includes a wide variety of artistic mediums, such as digital media, performance art, installations, photography, paintings, and sculptures. To engage viewers emotionally and intellectually, artists use a variety of styles and approaches, such as symbolism, metaphor, juxtaposition, and visual narrative. The portrayal of women at the nexus of art and political activism is a crucial and transformational part of artistic expression. It is an effective instrument for fighting against gender inequality, supporting women’s rights, and promoting social change. Artists have the power to captivate audiences and elicit critical thought through their work.

6.4 The diaspora and the negotiated self

Paintings that depict women in the diaspora investigate the lives, identities, and narratives of women who live outside of their countries of origin. This field of artistic expression is broad and diverse. A population's dispersal from its place of origin, frequently for political, economic, or social reasons, is referred to as a diaspora. Artists from the diaspora tackle the concepts of identity, belonging, cultural hybridity, displacement, and resilience in their works. Many Middle Eastern artists — Laila Shawa, Etel Adnan, Shirin Neshat, Ayman Baalbaki, Mona Hatoum — have presented women in their artworks while they have been away from home. They have discussed the difficulties of forming an identity, navigating conflicting cultural influences, and coping with life in unfamiliar places. Considerations of gender, ethnicity, religion, language, and social class are frequently reflected in these artistic creations.



Fig. 34 — Laila Shawa, Turkomania – Eternity, from the Women of Gaza Series, 1990. Shawa's overlay of decorative pattern and political iconography refuses the choice between the lyrical and the documentary.

Being a Palestinian artist in the diaspora, Laila Shawa was able to address the themes of displacement, identity, and conflict that are central to the Palestinian experience. Her work often reflects the struggles and challenges faced by Palestinians who have been forced to leave their homeland because of conflict and occupation. Through her art, she highlights the emotional and psychological impact of being uprooted from one's homeland and the ongoing struggle for justice and recognition. Laila Shawa (4 April 1940 – 24 October 2022) was a Palestinian visual artist

whose work has been described as a personal reflection concerning the politics of her country, particularly highlighting perceived injustices and persecution. She was one of the most prominent and prolific artists of the Arab revolutionary contemporary art scene; her best-known body of work, the Walls of Gaza series of the 1990s, repurposed photographs of graffiti from Gaza City as silkscreens with overlaid colour fields and decorative ornament. Eternity belongs to a related series, Women of Gaza, in which the figure of the Gazan woman becomes the screen on which the political and the lyrical are juxtaposed.

The examination of cultural heritage and the negotiation of identities are made possible by the representation of women from the diaspora in artworks. To evoke a sense of kinship with their origins, artists may use elements of traditional dress, iconography, or cultural customs. They may also illustrate the flexibility and adaptation of cultural identities, demonstrating how women balance their ancestry and the realities of their new environments. The difficulties faced by immigrant groups — racism, discrimination, marginalisation, and the difficulties of assimilation — are also highlighted by paintings of women in the diaspora. They might look into issues like preserving cultural traditions, fostering community, and overcoming adversity. Artists may disprove preconceptions, question prevailing narratives, and promote social justice and equality through their work.

[Image not available: Fig. 35 — Elie Kanaan, Girl in the Field, oil on canvas, 1980s. The painting's muted palette and the figure's averted face make it a quiet study in displacement.]

An example is the Lebanese artist Elie Kanaan (1926–2009), who was living in Paris, and who, in his painting *Girl in the Field* from the 1980s, depicted the sense of loneliness and solitude in a palette of warm greens and reds that offers a glimmer of hope against the dark blue. In presenting her in

this manner, Kanaan exemplifies further her isolation and what has led her to wander into the field alone. Although seemingly naïve in its composition and relatively muted brushstrokes, upon closer inspection the viewer realises that the lady's head is bowed in what appears to be sadness, with her back turned towards the viewer. Kanaan was born in Beirut in 1926 and quickly became a self-educated and very gifted painter. Already in his early twenties, he showed a very clear way of expressing his own colours throughout his first oil paintings. After that, his meeting with painters such as the French painter Georges Cyr would allow him to prove his talent. The colours are bright but deeply worked; the touches are audacious but never outrageous. Kanaan died in 2009.

Three further diasporic artists who deserve sustained discussion. Shirin Neshat (b. 1957), Iranian-American, has produced since her landmark *Women of Allah* series (1993–97) what is probably the single most internationally recognisable body of contemporary art associated with a Middle Eastern woman. Her photographs and films use Persian calligraphy (often the poetry of Forough Farrokhzad) inscribed on women's faces, hands, and feet, juxtaposed with the chador, the rifle, and the bare body. The work has been criticised by some Iranian feminists for re-Orientalising its subject matter; it has been embraced by others as the most powerful contemporary Western-language statement of the predicament of the post-1979 Iranian woman. Neshat herself has been candid about the divided position from which she works: she left Iran in 1974, returned only briefly after the revolution, and has lived since 1979 in New York. Her recent video installations — *Roja* (2016), *Land of Dreams* (2019) — have moved the work into new territory.

Mona Hatoum (b. 1952), Lebanese-Palestinian-British, is the second. Hatoum was born in Beirut to a Palestinian family that had been displaced from Haifa in 1948; she was visiting London in 1975 when the Lebanese

civil war broke out, and she could not return. She has lived in London since. Her work crosses sculpture, performance, and installation, and the female body — usually her own — has been a recurring subject (most famously in the 1994 video *Corps étranger*, in which an endoscopic camera enters her body and projects the interior onto a circular floor). Hatoum's 2016 retrospective at the Tate Modern travelled to the Centre Pompidou and the KIASMA in Helsinki — a degree of institutional recognition that has come more rarely to her contemporaries.

Etel Adnan (1925–2021), Lebanese-American, is the third. A poet first and a painter second, Adnan was already in her sixties when her painting began to attract sustained international attention, and only in her eighties — after her inclusion in Documenta 13 in 2012 — that she became an international art-world fixture. Her small, square canvases of brilliantly coloured planes derive simultaneously from Cézanne's *Mont Sainte-Victoire* (Adnan painted Mount Tamalpais in northern California, where she lived for decades), from Sufi cosmology, and from the modernist abstraction of her early teachers in Beirut and Paris. The work resists straightforward feminist or Middle Eastern reading; it claims a different kind of territory, in which the categories of Arab woman, lesbian, exile, modernist, mystic, polyglot writer all coexist without subordination.

There is no one particular style or method used to represent women in the diaspora artistically in paintings. Artists draw from a variety of artistic traditions, fusing elements of their cultural upbringing with more modern artistic techniques. This blending of techniques and aesthetics results in distinctive visual storytelling that engages, compels, and motivates viewers. Portraying women from around the world in paintings is a dynamic and developing form of artistic expression. It provides a forum for the study of identity, belonging, cultural hybridity, and resilience by artists. These pieces of art challenge preconceptions and amplify the voices of

women navigating different cultural influences in order to promote a greater awareness of the diasporic experience. Diaspora artists encourage conversation, create understanding, and advance a more inclusive and interconnected world through their craft and stories.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Gender, Sexuality, and the Male Gaze



Looking, Being Looked At, Looking Back

7.1 Introduction

Gender and sexuality are complex and multifaceted aspects of human existence, and their representation in Middle Eastern art reflects the diverse cultural, historical, and religious contexts of the region. Middle Eastern art has a long and rich history that encompasses a wide range of artistic expressions, including painting, sculpture, calligraphy, and architecture. Within these artistic traditions, gender and sexuality have been explored and depicted in various ways, influenced by societal norms, religious beliefs, and individual perspectives. One of the key aspects of gender and sexuality in Middle Eastern art is the representation of gender roles and expectations.

Basim Musallam's study of contraception (1983), the first monograph to focus on sexual practice in the Islamic world, combined scholarship gained in medieval sources with a vision of modern population methods.⁸ Judith

⁸Basim F. Musallam, *Sex and Society in Islam: Birth Control before the Nineteenth Century* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1983); Judith E. Tucker, *Women in Nineteenth-Century Egypt* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1985).

Tucker's seminal study of women in nineteenth-century Egypt (1985) examined the impact of technology and ideological modernisation on lower-class women in nineteenth-century Egypt and revealed conditions of female slavery. Studies of European thought were emerging at the same moment as the profound impact of Middle Eastern culture and history on students. The crisis of Western attitudes toward sexuality in the Orient was heightened in 1978 by the publication of Edward Said's *Orientalism* and in 1979 by Alain Grosrichard's *Structure du sérail: la fiction du despotisme asiatique dans l'Occident classique*. Together these texts gave the academic study of Middle Eastern sexuality a new political stake.

Traditional depictions often adhere to societal norms and present gender in a binary manner, with distinct roles and behaviours assigned to men and women. These portrayals may reflect cultural ideals of femininity and masculinity, emphasising modesty, virtue, and familial roles for women, while valorising strength, power, and leadership for men. However, Middle Eastern art is not limited to static or fixed representations of gender. Many contemporary artists challenge and subvert traditional gender norms, offering alternative perspectives and exploring the fluidity and diversity of gender identities. They address issues such as gender inequality, patriarchy, and the constraints placed on women's autonomy and self-expression. Through their artwork, they strive to break down stereotypes and question societal expectations surrounding gender roles and behaviours.

Farida Abu Aouf is an Egyptian artist, feminist, and queer activist, who is interested in defending LGBT rights in the Middle East, especially Egypt. Because of her beliefs, she was forced to immigrate to Canada. In an interview, Abu Aouf said: "What inspires me are women and girls. I express myself completely and freely when I work on my art. I do not feel self-censored when expressing my creativity in a painting. I decided to use my

art to express my feelings, experiences, and events that I share with other women and other people in the form of art, using colours and paintings. I express myself through art because art can deliver messages that transcend languages, cultures, and even time.” Her case is, sadly, not exceptional: a 2017 amendment to the Egyptian penal code criminalising the “promotion of homosexuality” has produced a steady trickle of refugee applications from queer Egyptian artists, and the Cairo art scene has, since the 2011 revolution, been progressively constricted by the broader political climate.

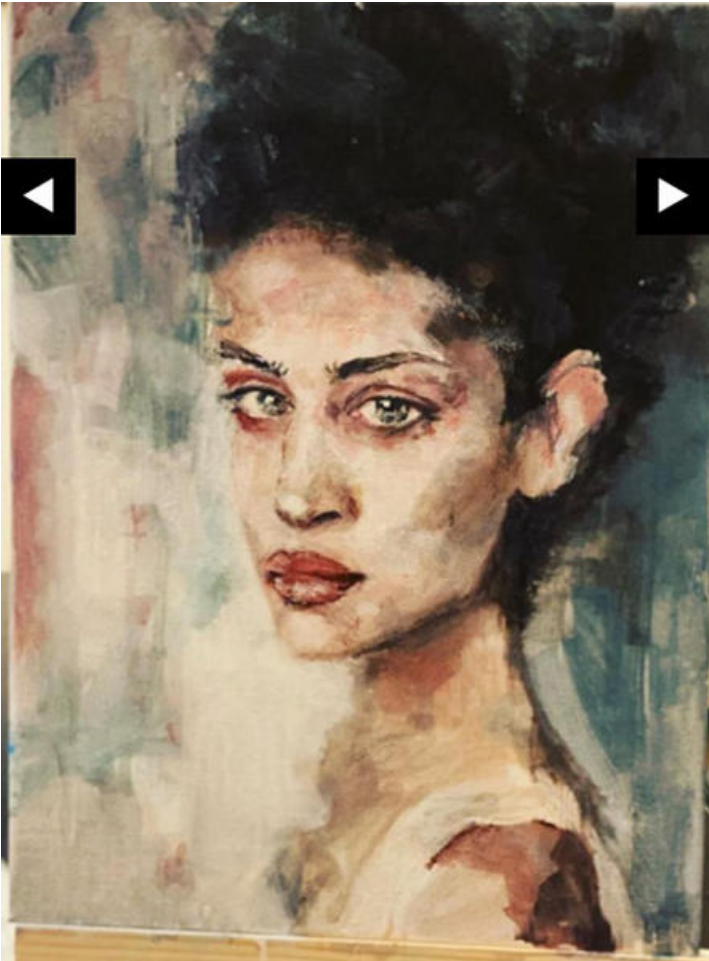


Fig. 36 — Farida Abu Aouf, photograph of the artist (Egypt / Canada). Abu Aouf left Egypt for Canada because of her open advocacy for LGBT rights.

Sexuality is another important aspect of Middle Eastern art, which is often influenced by cultural and religious beliefs. Islamic art, for example, traditionally emphasises modesty and tends to avoid explicit depictions of sexuality. Instead, sensuality and romantic themes are often conveyed through subtle symbolism, metaphorical imagery, and poetic expression. Love, desire, and spiritual connections are explored in a more metaphorical and allegorical manner, celebrating the beauty of human relationships and emotional experiences. The poetic tradition in this respect is much more permissive than the visual one: the wine poetry of Abu Nuwas (756–814 CE), the homoerotic ghazals of Hafiz (1320–1389), the love lyrics of Ibn al-Farid (1181–1235) — all of these provided the literary scaffolding on which a great deal of Middle Eastern visual culture was eventually built. The Persianate miniature painters of the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries illustrated those poems with full awareness of what they were illustrating.

Contemporary Middle Eastern art has increasingly embraced more explicit and open representations of sexuality. Artists challenge societal taboos and address topics such as desire, intimacy, and sexual identities. They explore the complexities of sexual experiences, including LGBTQ+ narratives, and shed light on the diverse expressions of human sexuality within the region. The portrayal of gender and sexuality in Middle Eastern art is not monolithic, as the region comprises various cultures, ethnicities, and religious beliefs. Different countries and communities within the Middle East have distinct artistic traditions and perspectives on gender and sexuality. Moreover, artists themselves have diverse viewpoints and may approach these subjects from different angles, reflecting their individual experiences, identities, and artistic visions. The representation

of gender and sexuality in Middle Eastern art is a reflection of the ever-evolving societal dynamics, cultural influences, and personal narratives. It serves as a means of expressing diverse perspectives, challenging social norms, and promoting dialogue around these complex and often sensitive topics. Middle Eastern artists continue to contribute to a broader understanding of gender and sexuality, expanding the boundaries of artistic expression and enriching the cultural landscape of the region.

7.2 Queer presence in Middle Eastern art

The depiction of lesbian, gay, bisexual, and transgender (LGBT) individuals in Middle Eastern art is a complex and evolving subject. The cultural, social, and religious diversity of the Middle East has shaped a wide range of artistic expressions, each with its own perspective on gender and sexuality. While traditional and historical depictions may have been limited or non-existent in some media, contemporary Middle Eastern art has increasingly explored and challenged societal norms, advocating for greater visibility and understanding of LGBT individuals.

Homosexuality in the Middle East was historically made into an illegal identity category — one that, many historians argue, did not exist in the same form prior to increased contact with Western explorers and travellers. The travelogue, which consists of books and manuscripts written by travellers from Europe to the Ottoman Middle East, provides instances of external vantage points that compare intimate sexual scripts between the West and the Other. As an apparatus from which Orientalism spread, these travelogues used homosociality in the Middle East as a sign of perverted morality and “stood for the Orient’s passivity, laziness, cowardice, and submission” (Ze’evi, 2006). It is important to understand how the emergence of what Joseph Massad has called the “Gay International” coincided with that of Western gay sexuality studies. These

issues are all at the forefront in the study of Islamicate sexualities. Diasporic artists provide a rich platform to investigate the relationship of both colonial trauma and displacement within Middle Eastern communities in North America, and how the conception of homeland complicates a transnational sexual identity. The classic recent monographs on the topic — Khaled El-Rouayheb's *Before Homosexuality in the Arab-Islamic World* (2005), Afsaneh Najmabadi's *Women with Mustaches and Men without Beards* (2005), Dror Ze'evi's *Producing Desire* (2006), and Joseph Massad's controversial *Desiring Arabs* (2007) — have, between them, transformed the field.

In recent years, there has been a growing movement within Middle Eastern contemporary art to address LGBT themes and experiences more directly. Artists have sought to challenge taboos, stereotypes, and discrimination faced by LGBT individuals in the region. Their work explores the complexities of sexual and gender identities, addressing issues such as coming out, self-acceptance, discrimination, and the intersectionality of multiple identities.

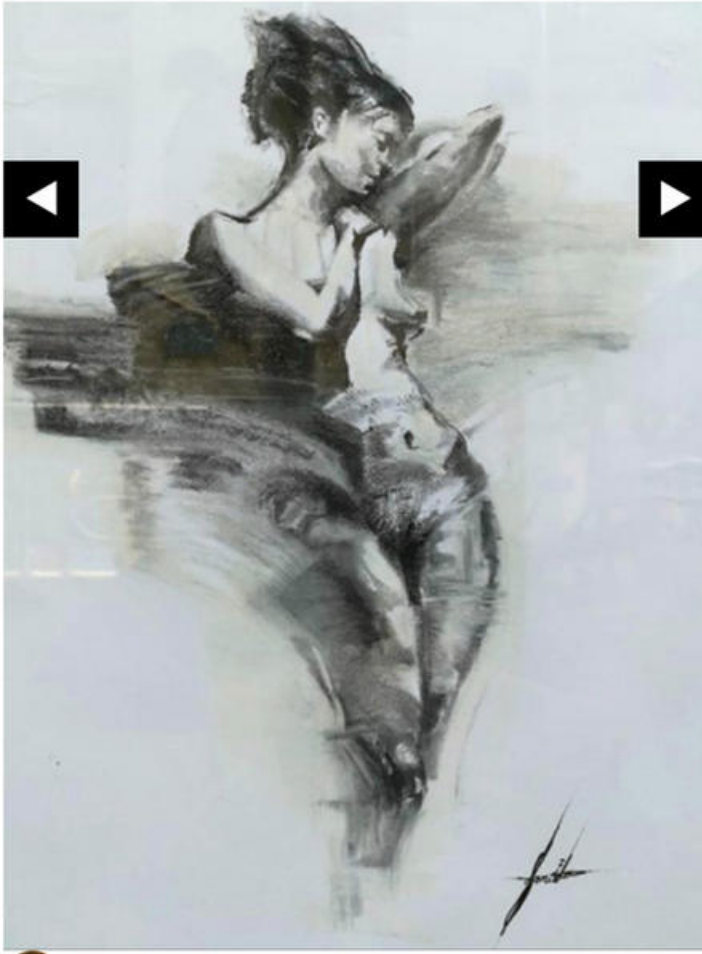


Fig. 37 — Taner Ceylan, Lucas, oil on canvas, 230 × 170 cm, 2022. Ceylan’s photo-realist technique brings to a contemporary subject matter the high-finish discipline of nineteenth-century European salon painting.

Turkish artist Taner Ceylan (b. 1967) translates his prodigious technical abilities from oil paintings to graphite and charcoal drawings with his series of work “Golden Age.” Ceylan’s emotionally charged paintings also reflect his personal life. His state of mind is reflected in his paintings as he once again shares the technical mastery of twentieth-century photo-realism. Ceylan, like other artists in Turkey, was attacked by pro-government newspapers and online accounts when the Istanbul

Metropolitan Municipality organised the exhibition Starting from the Middle, featuring works by some 300 contemporary artists from Turkey. Works singled out for criticism included Ceylan's *Ingres* (2015), a gender-bending portrait modelled after a famous Neoclassical painting, and a text accompanying Ekin Keser's installation *Any Touch Tears Me Up Now* (2023) that describes the difficulties the artist has faced as an LGBTQ+ person in Turkey.



Fig. 38 — Taner Ceylan, Ingres, oil on canvas, 2015. The painting reworks an iconic European Neoclassical composition to bend the gender of its subject — and was singled out for attack by pro-government Turkish newspapers in 2023.

The depiction of LGBT individuals in Middle Eastern art is not uniform across the region. Artists come from diverse cultural backgrounds and may face different challenges and levels of acceptance in their respective societies. Moreover, while there are artists who openly explore LGBT themes, there are others who may choose to express their identities and experiences more subtly or indirectly because of cultural or personal considerations. This depiction of LGBT individuals in Middle Eastern art is part of a larger global movement towards greater visibility and acceptance

of diverse sexual and gender identities. Through their creative expression, Middle Eastern artists are contributing to a more inclusive and nuanced understanding of LGBT experiences, challenging societal norms, and advocating for equality, human rights, and social justice.

One notable example of LGBT Middle Eastern art is the work of the Jordanian-American queer artist RIDIKKULUZ, who is based in New York. His work focuses on marginalised identities and their spaces through figurative portraiture. RIDIKKULUZ encompasses identity, duality, and intense emotion, all while bridging the gap between Western and Arab culture. The 2015 painting in Fig. 39 — acrylic, glitter, and soft sculpture on canvas — is characteristic. The figure's eyebrows arch sharply; the face is tilted at the angle of an icon; the soft sculpture protrudes from the canvas surface like a Byzantine relic that has been repurposed as drag kitchen-sink kitsch. The image is at once devotional and deliberately ridiculous, in keeping with the artist's self-deprecating chosen name.



Fig. 39 — RIDIKKULUZ, untitled work, acrylic, glitter, and soft sculpture on canvas, 72 × 48 cm, 2015. The image quotes the visual language of the Byzantine icon and re-routes it through the camp grammar of contemporary New York drag.



Fig. 40 — RIDIKKULUZ, Ridikkuluz About, acrylic, glitter, and soft sculpture on canvas, 72 × 48 cm, 2019.

Another example is the work of the Iranian artist Alireza Shojaian, born in 1988 in Tehran. He started his career in Tehran and Beirut and since 2019 has been based in Paris. His work aims to fight societal prejudice against LGBTQIA+ people while making space for non-heteronormative masculine identities. His work reflects on the queer history of West Asia, the present context, and his own experiences. Shojaian's queerness meant he could not continue his practice in Iran, where carnal depictions are censored and sexual identity is scrutinised and politicised. He has spoken publicly about the difficulty of being a queer Iranian artist in the diaspora — caught between, on one side, the Iranian state's outright criminalisation of his subject matter and, on the other, the European art world's sometimes too-eager appetite for the queer Iranian as a token of liberal cosmopolitanism.



Fig. 41 — Alireza Shojaiian, Gaëlle & Salwa, acrylic and coloured pencil on wood, 80 × 60 cm, 2022.

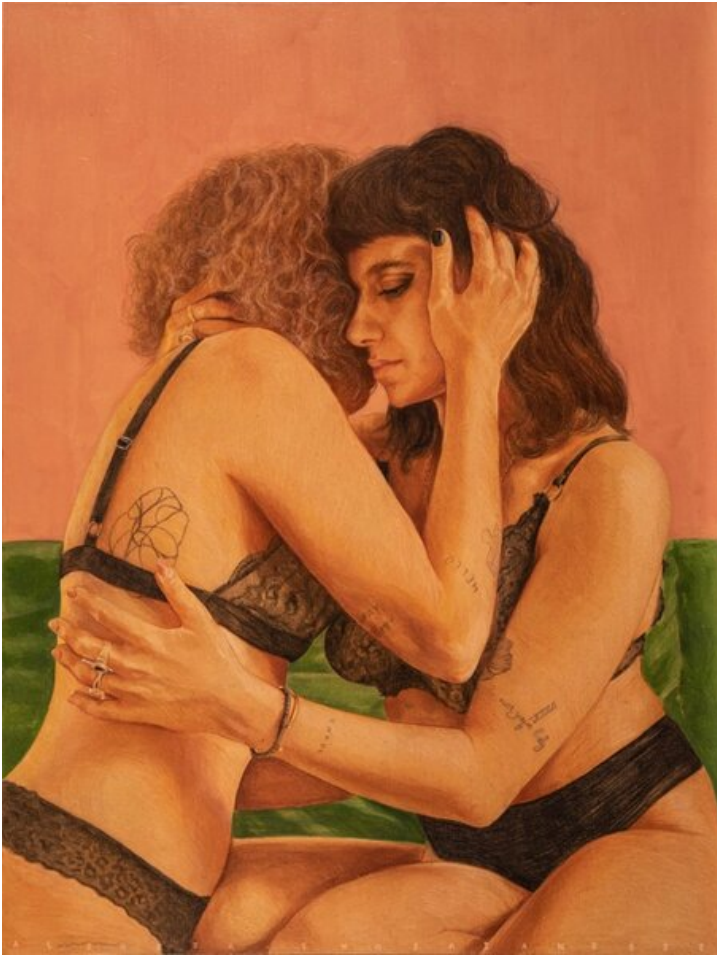


Fig. 42 — Alireza Shojaian, The Perfect Moment, acrylic and coloured pencil on wood, 100 × 125 cm. The painting's pose, palette, and light all quote the European pictorial tradition; the subject reroutes that tradition into queer Iranian self-representation.

These examples demonstrate the diversity of approaches and perspectives within LGBT Middle Eastern art. They highlight the artists' ability to navigate and challenge societal norms, address personal and collective experiences, and contribute to a more inclusive and nuanced understanding of gender and sexuality within the region. They also raise the difficult question of who, exactly, this art is for: queer Middle Eastern artists working in diaspora face real risks if they exhibit certain works in

their countries of origin, and the public for the art they make is therefore split between an international audience that may read the work too quickly through a Western progressive frame and a regional audience that, for political reasons, sometimes cannot see it at all.

7.3 The portrayal of the male gaze

The portrayal of the male gaze in Middle Eastern paintings is a complex and multifaceted topic that intersects with issues of gender, power dynamics, and societal norms. The male gaze refers to the way in which women are depicted and viewed from a heterosexual male perspective, often objectifying them and reducing them to objects of desire. While the concept of the male gaze is not exclusive to Middle Eastern art, it has influenced the portrayal of women in various cultural and historical contexts, including the Middle East.

The “male gaze” was first articulated by Laura Mulvey in 1975 in her essay “Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema,” in which she argued that classical Hollywood cinema is structured around the heterosexual male’s pleasure, consistently portraying women not as independent persons but as objects of the male gaze.⁹ In Michel Foucault’s *Discipline and Punish* (1975), the gaze itself is conceptualised as a disciplinary technology — a means by which power produces and regulates its subjects. Foucault’s analysis allows us to read the male gaze as one specific instance of a more general structure: the patriarchal gaze that turns women into surveilled objects, the colonial gaze that turns colonised peoples into ethnographic specimens, the medical gaze that turns patients into bodies. Read this way,

⁹Laura Mulvey, “Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema,” *Screen* 16, no. 3 (1975): 6–18; repr. in Mulvey, *Visual and Other Pleasures* (London: Macmillan, 1989).

the European Orientalist painting tradition combines all three gazes at once.

Many traditional Middle Eastern paintings — and a great deal of European Orientalist painting purporting to depict Middle Eastern subjects — have depicted women in ways that align with the male gaze. These artworks often feature idealised, passive, and sensualised female figures who are presented for the pleasure and consumption of the viewer. Women are frequently depicted in poses that accentuate their physical beauty, and their bodies are often objectified and sexualised through revealing clothing, provocative gestures, or alluring expressions. However, not all Middle Eastern art perpetuates the male gaze. Many contemporary artists challenge and subvert these traditional representations, offering alternative perspectives and empowering women by reclaiming their narratives and agency. These artists seek to disrupt and critique the dominant gaze by presenting women as active, complex individuals with their own desires, emotions, and experiences.

Contemporary Middle Eastern art explores a range of themes related to gender, sexuality, and power dynamics, often through the lens of feminist perspectives. Artists challenge societal expectations, address gender inequality, and provide counter-narratives to challenge the objectification and commodification of women. They aim to create a more inclusive and diverse representation of women, highlighting their strength, resilience, and multifaceted identities. Moreover, the male gaze is not exclusive to the depiction of women in Middle Eastern art. It can also be present in the portrayal of men, reinforcing and perpetuating traditional notions of masculinity and power. These depictions may reflect societal expectations and reinforce gender roles that limit both women and men.

As with any cultural expression, it is important to consider the historical, social, and artistic contexts when examining the portrayal of the male gaze

in Middle Eastern paintings. The European artists who painted Oriental scenes had visual conventions for depicting the white man as the unseen but pervasive observer. Artists did not express a given reality but, in fact, “created meanings” through their works. The white man was always present in a way that was at once self-evident and not directly visible — in the controlling eye, the eye that brought the Eastern world into being, that the vision was ultimately intended for. Linda Nochlin made this argument famously in her 1983 essay *The Imaginary Orient*, with reference to Gérôme’s *The Snake Charmer*.



Fig. 43 — Jean-Léon Gérôme, The Snake Charmer, oil on canvas, 83.8 × 122.1 cm, c. 1879.

Linda Nochlin’s 1983 essay on this painting made it the canonical case study for the analysis of the European Orientalist male gaze.

One of the most famous paintings that exemplifies this type of painting is *The Snake Charmer* by French artist Jean-Léon Gérôme. In this painting of

around 1879, a half-naked Middle Eastern young person plays a flute while surrounded by a group of male spectators, including what may be a Western traveller. The composition and framing, along with the presence of male figures, emphasise the sense of voyeurism and the male gaze, positioning the viewer as an observer of a body that has been displayed for the painting's implied client. Commenting on Gérôme's *The Snake Charmer*, Linda Nochlin argued that "the emotion that defines the painting is a mystery" and "a sexually charged mystery means something general: the mystery of the former itself, the standard topos of Oriental thought." The picture depicted a "gathering" of Orientals watching a play, and the audience and "performers" seemed far removed from the "authentic mystery" of the viewer and the subjects to be drawn to isolation makes sense because it implied isolation — unfamiliar Western viewer with what was depicted. In other words, for the white man, the visual psychological message was that the former was a distant reality morally, socially, and emotionally excluded — a disgust that could only respond with isolated shock, curiosity, or even erotic pleasure. The "absence of a sense of history, the change of time" in Gérôme's painting is another important observation made by Nochlin.



Fig. 44 — Giulio Rosati, Inspecting New Arrivals, oil on canvas, 1917. The painting's premise — male buyers inspecting newly arrived enslaved women — turns the slave market into a spectacle for the European viewer's consumption.

Another example is the work of the Italian artist Giulio Rosati, who specialised in Orientalist paintings depicting harem scenes. His paintings often featured veiled or partially nude women in luxurious surroundings, surrounded by male figures who gaze upon them. These images, while visually stunning, reinforce the exoticised and sexualised representation of Middle Eastern women, catering to the male viewer's fantasies and desires. *Inspecting New Arrivals* (1917) is more sinister than its title suggests: the “new arrivals” are women in the slave market, and the painting exists in the visual tradition that includes Gérôme's *The Slave Market* (c. 1866) and a number of works by Otto Pilny. The chronology is worth pausing on: the European Orientalist genre was still painting these scenes in 1917, three years after Britain and France had committed themselves at the Treaty of London to the partition of the Ottoman Empire, and at the moment when the formal slave trade had been outlawed in most of the territories the painting purports to represent. The Orientalist slave market belongs, by 1917, to the iconography of European fantasy rather than to any current Middle Eastern reality.

It is worth noting that these Orientalist paintings were created by Western artists and were often influenced by their own cultural biases and colonial perspectives. They do not necessarily reflect the authentic experiences or perspectives of Middle Eastern women. However, these artworks have played a significant role in shaping Western perceptions and stereotypes about the region and its people, perpetuating the male gaze and reinforcing power dynamics based on gender and cultural differences. To approach these paintings critically is to consider the broader historical and sociopolitical context in which they were created. Contemporary artists from the Middle East have challenged and subverted these Orientalist representations, offering alternative narratives and perspectives that challenge the male gaze and provide more nuanced and empowering portrayals of women.

7.4 Counter-gazes and feminist reframings

What does it mean to “look back” at the painting that has been looking at you for a hundred and fifty years? The recent generation of Middle Eastern feminist artists has answered this question in a remarkable variety of ways. Lalla Essaydi, as already discussed, restages the European Orientalist composition with women whose entire surfaces are inscribed with their own writing. The Iranian-American Shadi Ghadirian (b. 1974), in her Qajar series (1998–2001), photographed Iranian women in nineteenth-century Qajar dress posing with twentieth-century objects — a vacuum cleaner, a Pepsi can, a boom-box. The juxtaposition makes ridiculous the Orientalist insistence on the “timeless East” without ever raising its voice. The Lebanese-Palestinian-British Mona Hatoum, in her video installations, has used her own body to interrupt the iconography of the female body as a transparent surface for someone else’s desire.

These projects all share a refusal of the binary in which the male gaze has trapped its subjects: not “covered or uncovered,” not “oriental or occidental,” not “seen or not seen,” but a third position in which the woman returns the look, with full knowledge of what she is doing. The art of looking back is not the abolition of the gaze; it is the recovery of the second person inside it.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Toward a Plural History



Conclusion

The representation of women in Middle Eastern paintings is a complex and multifaceted issue. No single image of Middle Eastern women is unique in art, as the region is culturally and nationally diverse. However, some generalities can be found. A common theme is the portrayal of women as exotic and mysterious. This is particularly evident in the work of European Orientalists who often depicted Middle Eastern women as veiled and solitary creatures shrouded in mystery. This image can be seen as a Western perception of the East which made the cultures of the Middle East appear strange and provocative — a perception engineered, as Edward Said argued in 1978, to serve the political project of colonisation that needed to imagine a passive, available East at exactly the moment that European powers were undertaking, in literal fact, the partition of the region.

Another observation across the chapters of this book has been the portrayal of women as passive and submissive. This is often seen in harem depictions, where women are the only ones in the home and ostensibly under the control of men. This image can be seen as a reflection of the traditional patriarchal values of many Middle Eastern countries — though, as I have repeatedly argued, the reading is too simple. The actual harem of the Ottoman, Safavid, Mughal, or Qajar court was a complex institution

within which women exercised, on occasion, considerable political power; the “harem” of European painting is largely a fantasy, and reading the latter back into the former does damage to both. There are also images that challenge these stereotypes. Some images present women as strong and independent, while others show them participating in society. These portraits offer a nuanced and complex view of Middle Eastern women, helping to break the stereotypes often established in art.

The representation of women in Middle Eastern paintings is a fascinating fabric woven with threads of historical, cultural, religious, and artistic interpretation. It spans a larger picture from antiquity to modern times, each holding its own moment and unique location, with its own iconographic inscriptions. The depiction of women in Middle Eastern art is a complex negotiation of tradition and change, reflecting the societies and beliefs that have shaped the region for millennia. These images were not only the result of changing social norms and religious influences but also mirrored the aspirations, struggles, and resilience of women in the Middle East — from goddess-like figures symbolising fertility and abundance in the ancient world, through the icons of Mary and Fatima in the medieval period, through the harem fantasy and the modern portrait of the long nineteenth century, into the contemporary paintings, photographs, and films of the post-colonial generation.

Moreover, in the modern era, the voices of women artists have risen, challenging traditional representations and contributing to a beautifully inclusive narrative. Their work reflects the changing position of women in the profession, addressing issues of identity, empowerment, and the constant nexus between tradition and modernity. The artists I have discussed here — Mihri Müşfik Hanım, Mahmoud Said (himself a man, but a man who painted women with respect, as fellow citizens of the new modern Egypt he was helping to imagine), Tahia Halim, Saloua Raouda

Choucair, Etel Adnan, Lalla Essaydi, Shirin Neshat, Mona Hatoum, Huguette Caland, Nabil Anani, Saba Jallas, Laila Shawa, Zerrin Tekindor, Taner Ceylan, Alireza Shojaian, Farida Abu Aouf, RIDIKKULUZ — share, between them, the property that no single account can subsume them. They want, and deserve, plural histories.

One more important observation: studying gender and sexuality in Middle Eastern paintings invites an examination of multicultural influences, colonial and Orientalist inflections, and local ethnic differences in artistic expression. This can explore the artistic techniques and symbols that play an important role in the nuances of the relevant message — gender and sexuality. The contemporary moment in particular reframes how the older paintings can be read. Looking at Gérôme's *The Bath* through the lens of contemporary Black feminist art history (Kimberly Drew, Tina Campt, Saidiya Hartman), or looking at Fabbi's harem fantasies through the categories developed by Reina Lewis and Mary Roberts in their work on Ottoman women's self-representation, one finds whole new layers of meaning that the original viewers of these images could not have seen and that, in some cases, the painters themselves did not intend.

This area of study is not limited to the historical perspective. Contemporary artists from the Middle East engage with and challenge social norms, offering new insights and perspectives on these issues through their work. They also operate, increasingly, in conditions of regional crisis — the Syrian war, the long Israeli-Palestinian conflict and the war in Gaza, the post-2017 reconstruction of Iraq, the long Yemeni civil war, the Iranian women's movement of 2022–23 — that have made the question of how to represent the Middle Eastern woman a question of historical urgency. The art produced under such conditions has consequences. It will become, in time, the iconography by which this period of regional history is remembered.

Finally, the representation of women in Middle Eastern paintings is not a monolith but a living testament to the diversity and complexity of the region, which invites us to explore, absorb, and acknowledge the nuances of Middle Eastern culture as we transcend boundaries and time. Ultimately, it is a reminder of the enduring power of art to express and shape our understanding of the world around us. The faces in these paintings — Mary and Fatima, the Khedive's court ladies and the Persian princesses, the Nubian women of Aswan and the Palestinian mothers of the West Bank, the Tehrani photo-portraits and the New York drag self-portraits — share a single quality. They keep their own counsel. They have looked back at every viewer who has ever stood in front of them, and they will keep looking. The work of the art historian is, finally, a work of patience: to stand in front of these images long enough to learn what they have been trying to tell us.

"The history of art does not consist in writing the lives of the artists, but in narrating the patient labour of seeing."

— Daniel Arasse

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